

RTL Design Sherpa

KESTREL-RV32I Micro-Architecture Specification 0.1

October 7, 2026

Table of Contents

1 Kestrel Mas Index....12

2 Document Information....13

2.1 KESTREL-RV32I Micro-Architecture Specification....13

2.2 Document Purpose....14

2.3 References....15

2.4 Terminology....16

2.5 Revision History....17

3 Design Philosophy and Machine Organization....18

3.1 Design Philosophy....18

3.2 The Machine in One Picture....19

3.2.1 Figure 1.1: kestrel datapath block diagram....19

3.3 Module Inventory....20

3.4 State Inventory....22

3.5 Key Interfaces at a Glance....23

4 kestrel_core (Top)....24

4.1 Purpose....24

4.2 Interface....25

4.3 Internal Structure....26

4.3.1 Fetch....26

4.3.2 Source Muxes....26

4.3.3 Writeback Priority Mux....26

4.3.4 Next-PC Mux....27

4.3.5 Branch Comparator (the Ruling)....27
4.3.6 Load/Store Rotation Network....27
4.3.7 Halt and PC Registers....28
5 kestrel_decode....29
5.1 Purpose....29
5.2 Keying and Defaults....30
5.3 The Decode Table....31
5.3.1 Arithmetic and upper-immediate rows....31
5.3.2 Loads, stores, branches, jumps....32
5.3.3 System, fence, and the default....33
5.4 What the Table Teaches....35
6 kestrel_imm_gen....36
6.1 Purpose....36
6.2 Interface....37
6.3 Internal Structure....38
7 kestrel_alu....40
7.1 Purpose....40
7.2 Interface....41
7.3 Operations....42
7.4 The Flags Ruling....43
8 kestrel_regfile....44
8.1 Purpose....44
8.2 Interface....45
8.3 Internal Structure and Rules....46

9 kestrel_mem_loader..... 47
9.1 Purpose..... 47
9.1.1 Figure 2.1: Loader composition.....47
9.2 Memory Arrays.....48
9.3 CTRL / Run Register and Reset Sequencing.....49
9.4 Write Side: Leaf Slave plus Two Holding Bits.....50
9.5 Read Side: Combinational Beat through the AR Skid.....51
9.6 Address Map, as Implemented.....52
9.7 Debug Taps.....53
10 Package Types and Top-Level Wiring.....54
10.1 kestrel_pkg.....54
10.1.1 ALU operation enum (alu_op_e, 4 bits).....54
10.1.2 Immediate-format enum (imm_sel_e, 3 bits).....54
10.1.3 Halt-cause encodings (localparam logic [3:0]).....54
10.2 Top-Level Wiring (kestrel_core).....56
10.3 Reset Discipline.....58
11 The Single Cycle, Step by Step.....59
11.1 The Clock in One Sentence.....59
11.2 1. Fetch and Decode.....60
11.3 2. Operands and Immediates.....61
11.4 3. Execute.....62
11.5 4. Memory Access.....63
11.6 5. Writeback.....64
11.7 6. Next-PC Selection and the Edge.....65

11.8 The Basic Cycle on the Pins....66
11.8.1 Waveform 4.1: Basic single-cycle execution — an aligned load followed by an ALU op....66
11.9 Branch and Jump Resolution....67
12 Cross-Word Misaligned Retry....68
12.1 When the Retry Fires....68
12.2 Beat-by-Beat Behavior....69
12.3 The Waveform....70
12.3.1 Waveform 4.2: Cross-word store retry — SH at byte offset 3....70
12.4 Worked Example: a Halfword Across the Boundary....71
12.5 Why Hardware, Why Two Cycles....72
13 Halt, IALIGN, and the System Layer....73
13.1 The Halt Holding Register....73
13.2 The IALIGN Halt (Cause 3)....74
13.3 The System Layer: Stubs, NOPs, and Halts....75
13.3.1 FENCE and FENCE.I retire as NOPs....75
13.3.2 MRET falls through....75
13.3.3 The CSR class retires as a bounded stub....75
13.4 Halt Timing Summary....76
14 RVFI Aggregation....77
14.1 Retirement as the Observation Channel....77
14.2 The Field Table....78
14.3 The Three Gating Rules....79
14.4 Memory-Field Packing....80

14.5 Why This Pays....81
15 Verification Hooks and Observability....82
15.1 The Three Testplan-Tracked Hooks....82
15.2 Supporting Hooks....84
15.3 The Consumer Stack....85
15.4 Cross-Reference to the Testplan Set....86
16 Parameters, Defines, and Filelists....87
16.1 Parameters....87
16.1.1 kestrel_core....87
16.1.2 kestrel_mem_loader....87
16.2 Defines and Includes....88
16.3 Filelists....89
16.4 Regenerating This Document....90
17 KESTREL-RV32I Hardware Architecture Specification Index....91
17.1 Document Organization....92
17.1.1 Front Matter....92
17.1.2 Chapter 1: Introduction....92
17.1.3 Chapter 2: System Overview....92
17.1.4 Chapter 3: Architecture....92
17.1.5 Chapter 4: Interfaces....92
17.1.6 Chapter 5: Performance....92
17.1.7 Chapter 6: Integration....92
17.2 Related Documentation....93
18 Simplified RV32I: kestrel....94

18.1 Overview..... 95
18.2 Document Structure..... 96
18.2.1 Chapter 1: Introduction..... 96
18.2.2 Chapter 2: The RV32I ISA Quick Reference..... 96
18.2.3 Chapter 3: The kestrel Datapath..... 96
18.2.4 Chapter 4: The Control Truth Table..... 96
18.2.5 Chapter 5: The Memory Contract..... 96
18.2.6 Chapter 6: Verification..... 97
18.2.7 Chapter 7: What kestrel Costs..... 97
18.2.8 Version History..... 97
19 RISC-V Falcon Suite..... 98
19.1 The ladder..... 99
19.1.1 Moved: hive-serv..... 100
19.1.2 Tetrad engine: gatling-rv32itetrad..... 100
19.2 Goals per rung..... 101
19.3 Packaging (per rung, the MC-line treatment)..... 102
19.4 References and layout..... 103
20 RISC-V Formal Interface (RVFI)..... 104
20.1 RVFI Specification..... 104
20.1.1 Instruction Metadata..... 104
20.1.2 Integer Register Read/Write..... 105
20.1.3 Program Counter..... 105
20.1.4 Memory Access..... 106
20.1.5 Alternative Arithmetic Operations..... 106

20.1.6 Control and Status Registers (CSRs)....107
20.1.7 Handling of Speculative Execution....107
20.2 RVFI TODOs and Requests for Comments....109
20.2.1 Support for fused instructions....109
20.2.2 Modelling of Floating-Point State....109
20.2.3 Modelling of Virtual Memory....109
20.2.4 Modelling of Atomic Memory Operations....111
20.2.5 Skipping instructions....111
21 kestrel-rv32i Testplans....113
21.1 Inventory....114
21.2 What each plan covers....115
21.3 JUnit naming convention (observed)....116
21.4 Rollup....117
21.5 Running the tests....118
21.6 Functional coverage (CORE-18)....119

List of Figures

Figure 1.1: kestrel datapath block diagram.....19
Figure 2.1: Loader composition.....47

List of Tables

Table 1: Reference Documents....15
Table 2: Terminology and Definitions....16
Table 3: Document Revision History....17
Table 4: Module inventory....20
Table 5: The complete core state inventory, register file aside....22
Table 6: Internal interface summary (full wiring in Chapter 3)....23
Table 7: Writeback priority mux....26
Table 8: The thirteen decode outputs....29
Table 9: Decode rows — OP, OP-IMM, LUI, AUIPC....31
Table 10: Decode rows — LOAD, STORE, BRANCH, JAL, JALR....32
Table 11: Decode rows — SYSTEM, MISC-MEM, and the illegal default....33
Table 12: kestrel_imm_gen interface....37
Table 13: Immediate assembly per format....38
Table 14: kestrel_alu interface....41
Table 15: ALU operations (shamt = b[4:0])....42
Table 16: kestrel_regfile interface....45
Table 17: Loader map implementation facts....52
Table 18: alu_op_e enumerators....54
Table 19: imm_sel_e enumerators....54
Table 20: HALT_* encodings — the single source of truth shared by decode and core....54
Table 21: kestrel_core internal wiring map....56
Table 22: Control-transfer resolution....67
Table 23: The two beats of a cross-word access (o = addr[1:0])....69
Table 24: Halt timing at the boundary....76
Table 25: RVFI signals and their kestrel aggregation....78
Table 26: The three testplan-tracked hooks....82
Table 27: Supporting loader hooks....84
Table 28: Verification consumer stack....85
Table 29: kestrel_core parameters....87
Table 30: kestrel_mem_loader parameters....87
Table 31: Shared defines....88
Table 32: Filelists (KESTREL_ROOT = projects/components/riscv-ip/kestrel-rv32i; REPO_ROOT = RTLDesignSherpa checkout root)....89
Table 33: Version history....97

List of Waveforms

Waveform 4.1: Basic single-cycle execution — an aligned load followed by an ALU op..... 66
Waveform 4.2: Cross-word store retry — SH at byte offset 3.....70

1 Kestrel Mas Index

Generated: 2026-10-20

RTL Design Sherpa · Learning Hardware Design Through Practice GitHub · Documentation Index · MIT License

---

2 Document Information

2.1 KESTREL-RV32I Micro-Architecture Specification

Document Number: KESTREL-MAS-001 **Version:** 0.3 **Status:** Draft **Classification:** Open Source - MIT License

2.2 Document Purpose

This Micro-Architecture Specification (MAS) describes how the kestrel-rv32i core is built: one section per functional block covering its purpose, interface, internal structure, and key logic; the internal interfaces between blocks; the cycle-level behavior including the misaligned retry and halt timing; the verification hooks the design exposes on purpose; and the configuration surface. It is written for implementers and maintainers of the RTL, and for reviewers who need to check the design against its specification.

The external contract — ports as an integrator wires them, memory and halt behavior, loader programming — is the companion Hardware Architecture Specification (HAS). This document assumes it.

Target Audience: - RTL maintainers extending or fixing the core - Design reviewers checking implementation against intent - Verification engineers wiring checkers to the internal observability points - Students reading the RTL top to bottom

Companion Documents: - KESTREL-RV32I Hardware Architecture Specification (HAS) - External architecture and integration contract - Simplified RV32I: kestrel - Tutorial-study book covering the same ground as pedagogy

---

2.3 References

Reference Documents

ID	Document	Description
[REF-1]	KESTREL HAS v0.1	Hardware Architecture Specification (companion)
[REF-2]	RISC-V Instruction Set Manual, Volume I: Unprivileged Architecture (`projects/components/riscv-ip/references/riscv-spec.pdf`)	ISA authority; cited by chapter/section as “unpriv §N”
[REF-3]	riscv-formal `rvfi.md` (`vendor/riscv-formal/docs/rvfi.md`)	RVFI retire-channel field semantics
[REF-4]	KESTREL testplans (`dv/testplans/*.yaml`)	V&V scenarios and coverage cross-reference
[REF-5]	falcon-suite RTL style brief	Datapath-as-truth-tables / FSMs-only-where-unavoidable discipline

2.4 Terminology

Terminology and Definitions

Term	Definition
Beat	One memory access cycle; a cross-word access uses two beats
Control bundle	The thirteen-field decode output steering the datapath each cycle
FUB	Functional Unit Block - leaf RTL module
Halt holding register	`halt_q` — one bit that latches any halt cause and holds it
Retry bit	`ls_retry` — one bit of control state sequencing the cross-word retry
Rotator	The byte-lane shift network implementing rotated strobes/data for L/S
Trap beat	The single RVFI beat of a halting instruction (`rvfi_trap=1`)

2.5 Revision History

Document Revision History

Version	Date	Author	Description
0.1	2026-10-07	seang	Initial MAS release; documents the as-built RTL (Tasks 1-11) including the Task-9 IALIGN halt and the Task-11 AXIL board loader
0.2	2026-10-20	seang	Block diagrams redrawn to the repo element key (v3): class fills, double-bordered registered blocks, green return paths and a generated key under each figure. No technical content changed.
0.3	2026-10-20	seang	Section (h2) headings now open a new page, the pipeline default. No technical content changed.

Last Updated: 2026-10-07

RTL Design Sherpa · Learning Hardware Design Through Practice GitHub · Documentation Index · MIT License

3 Design Philosophy and Machine Organization

3.1 Design Philosophy

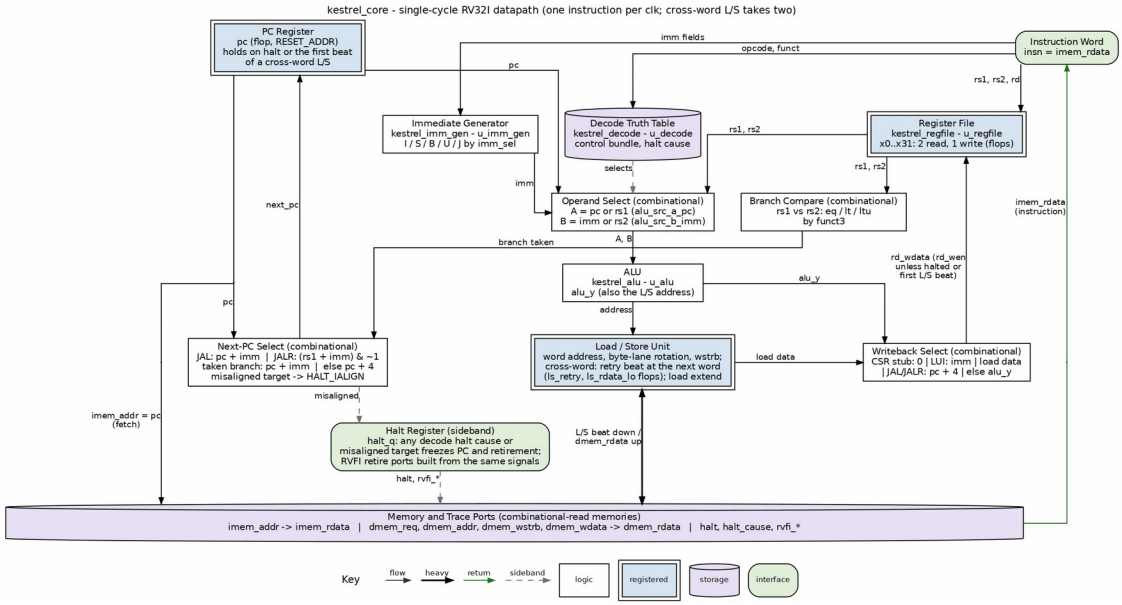
Three commitments shape the microarchitecture, and every block chapter shows them landing:

1. **The datapath is FSM-free.** Classic processor control walks fetch/decode/execute/memory/writeback as states; in kestrel those phases are spatial, not temporal. Fetch is a wire off the PC register; decode is a truth table; execute is an ALU; memory access is a combinational port; writeback is a mux feeding a clocked register file. There is nothing to sequence, so there is no FSM — and no microcode, no control ROM, no phase counter. The two places a naive design would reach for an FSM — halting and the misaligned retry — are single holding flops with plain set/clear conditions.
2. **Control is an explicit truth table.** Decode is one `unique casez` keyed on `{opcode, funct3, funct7}` producing a thirteen-field control bundle. The same word always produces the same bundle; the table is small enough to read top to bottom and is transcribed in the kestrel_decode chapter.
3. **RVFI is the observation channel.** The retire port is not debug instrumentation bolted on afterward; it is the defined observation channel, present from the first vertical slice, and its aggregation rules are stated next to the assignments in the RTL and again in Chapter 4.

The discipline the suite's style brief imposes — datapath logic is truth tables and muxes; FSMs only where control is unavoidable — is what makes this core reviewable in one sitting and provable at shallow model-checking depth (riscv-formal runs at depth 6 and covers reset plus a two-cycle memory access with headroom).

3.2 The Machine in One Picture

3.2.1 Figure 1.1: kestrel datapath block diagram



kestrel datapath block diagram

The diagram is drawn to match the RTL: the blocks are the module instances in `kestrel_core.sv`, and every named wire is a real signal in the source. State elements are the PC register, the register file, and three small holding registers described below; everything else is combinational.

3.3 Module Inventory

Module inventory

Module	File	Role	State
`kestrel_pkg`	`rtl/includes/kestrel_pkg.sv`	Shared enums (`alu_op_e`, `imm_sel_e`) and the halt-cause encodings	none
`kestrel_decode`	`rtl/fub/kestrel_decode.sv`	Combinational truth table from `{opcode, funct3, funct7}` to the control bundle	none
`kestrel_imm_gen`	`rtl/fub/kestrel_imm_gen.sv`	Builds the 32-bit immediate for the five formats	none
`kestrel_alu`	`rtl/fub/kestrel_alu.sv`	Ten operations: ADD SUB AND OR XOR SLL SRL SRA SLT SLTU	none
`kestrel_regfile`	`rtl/fub/kestrel_regfile.sv`	32 x 32-bit registers, two combinational read ports, one synchronous write, x0 discarded	32 words
`kestrel_core`	`rtl/top/kestrel_core.sv`	Wires the leaves together: source muxes, branch comparator, next-PC mux, writeback mux,	5 elements below

Module	File	Role	State
		L/S rotation, halt, RVFI	
`kestrel_mem_loader`	`rtl/fub/kestrel_mem_loader.sv`	Optional board glue: memories + AXIL slave + run control (see its chapter)	run bit, holding regs

3.4 State Inventory

Everything kestrel remembers, outside the register file and (when integrated) the memories:

The complete core state inventory, register file aside

Element	Width	Purpose	Next-state equation
`pc`	32	Program counter; resets to `RESET_ADDR`	`pc <= halt ? pc : (ls_first ? pc : next_pc)`
`retire_count`	64	RVFI retirement order: 0, 1, 2, …	`+1` when `rvfi_valid`
`halt_q`	1	Halt holding register; latches any halt cause	`halt_q <= halt_q | halt_now`
`ls_retry`	1	Cross-word L/S retry-cycle flag	`ls_retry <= ls_first`
`ls_rdata_lo`	32	First-word read data captured for the retry-cycle merge	captures `ls_rdata_shifted` when `ls_first`

Five state elements with one-line next-state equations are reviewable in minutes. The retry bit and the halt bit are control state only; `ls_rdata_lo` is the only place data is captured mid-instruction — a pipeline register in the most minimal sense.

3.5 Key Interfaces at a Glance

Internal interface summary (full wiring in Chapter 3)

Interface	Width	Producer → Consumer
Control bundle	13 fields	`kestrel_decode` → muxes, regfile, L/S datapath
`imm`	32	`kestrel_imm_gen` → source-B mux, writeback (LUI)
`alu_y`	32	`kestrel_alu` → dmem address, writeback
Branch flags	eq/lt/ltu	dedicated comparator → branch-cond mux → next-PC mux
`next_pc`	32	next-PC mux → PC register and `rvfi_pc_wdata`
`rd_wdata`	32	writeback mux → register file
RVFI bundle	17 signals	aggregation assigns → top-level ports

Last Updated: 2026-10-07

---

4 kestrel_core (Top)

4.1 Purpose

`kestrel_core` wires the four datapath leaves together and owns everything that is not a leaf: source muxes, the dedicated branch comparator, the next-PC mux, the writeback priority mux, the load/store rotation network with its retry state, the halt holding register, and the RVFI aggregation assigns. It is the only module in the core with architectural state besides the register file.

4.2 Interface

Ports are specified exhaustively in the HAS (Chapter 4 there). Internally the top exposes no hierarchy below the four leaf instances (`u_decode`, `u_imm_gen`, `u_regfile`, `u_alu`) plus its own always-blocks; the loader, when used, sits outside this module.

4.3 Internal Structure

4.3.1 Fetch

`imem_addr = pc` and `insn = imem_rdata` — fetch is a wire. The instruction is expected combinationally (the memory contract, HAS Ch. 4); `opcode = insn[6:0]` and `funct3 = insn[14:12]` fan out to decode and the L/S size/sign logic.

4.3.2 Source Muxes

`alu_src_a = alu_src_a_pc ? pc : rs1_data` selects PC (AUIPC, branch targets) or rs1. `alu_src_b = alu_src_b_imm ? imm : rs2_data` selects the immediate or rs2. Register-file read addresses come straight from the instruction: `rs1 = insn[19:15]`, `rs2 = insn[24:20]`, `rd = insn[11:7]`.

4.3.3 Writeback Priority Mux

`rd_wdata` is selected by a five-row priority mux:

Writeback priority mux

Priority	Condition	Value
1	`csr_stub`	`32'd0` — the CSR stub's zero writeback
2	`opcode == OPCODE_LUI`	`imm` — LUI never passes through the ALU
3	`ls_load`	`ls_load_data` — assembled, size/sign-corrected read data
4	`jump || jalr`	`pc + 4` — the link value
5	default	`alu_y`

The write enable is `rd_wen_eff = rd_wen & ~ls_first & ~halt`: decode's `rd_wen` qualified by the cross-word retry's first cycle (a partial word must not commit early) and by halt (the cause-3 halt retires JAL/JALR encodings whose decode `rd_wen` is set, so the gate is `halt` itself, not decode). The register file independently discards writes to x0.

4.3.4 Next-PC Mux

Four rows, in priority order: JAL/JALR (`jump || jalr`) → `jalr ? (rs1_data + imm) & 32'hFFFF_FFFE : pc + imm`; taken branch (`branch_taken`) → `pc + imm`; default → `pc + 4`. `JALR_ALIGN_MASK = 32'hFFFF_FFFE` clears target bit 0 per unpriv §2.1.5.1. In a single-cycle machine the branch decision and the `pc + imm` target settle in parallel, so taken and not-taken branches cost the same cycle.

4.3.5 Branch Comparator (the Ruling)

The ALU exports `eq/lt/ltu` flags, and the core's ALU instance **deliberately leaves them unconnected** (`.eq (), .lt (), .ltu ()`). The reason is a reviewed design ruling: for branches the ALU's left input is the PC (it is simultaneously computing `pc + imm` for the next-PC mux), so its internal flags would compare pc against imm, not rs1 against rs2 — silently wrong branch decisions. Branch conditions therefore come from a dedicated comparator on the register data:

- `cmp_eq = (rs1_data == rs2_data)`
- `cmp_lt = ($signed(rs1_data) < $signed(rs2_data))`
- `cmp_ltu = (rs1_data < rs2_data)`
- `branch_cond` selected from `cmp_*` by `funct3` in a `unique case` (BEQ→eq, BNE→~eq, BLT→lt, BGE→~lt, BLTU→ltu, BGEU→~ltu, default→0)
- `branch_taken = branch & branch_cond`

In a single-cycle machine this parallel evaluation is free: both the ALU result and the comparator decision are ready when the next PC is chosen.

4.3.6 Load/Store Rotation Network

The L/S datapath implements the hardware-misaligned policy (unpriv §2.1.6 permits hardware handling; the plan records it as a decision). For an access at byte offset `o = alu_y[1:0]` with size `s` bytes:

- **Size decode:** `dmem_size` (00 byte, 01 half, 10 word) → `ls_size_bytes` (1/2/4), `ls_size_mask` (0001/0011/1111), `ls_data_mask` (0xFF/0xFFFF/0xFFFFFFFF).
- **Split arithmetic:** `ls_tail_size = 4 - o`; `ls_head_size = s - ls_tail_size`; `ls_crossing = ls_active & (o + s > 4)`; `ls_first = ls_crossing & ~ls_retry`; `ls_second = ls_retry`; `ls_single = ls_active & ~ls_crossing`.
- **Address:** `dmem_addr = ls_second ? {alu_y[31:2] + 1, 2'b00} : {alu_y[31:2], 2'b00}` — beat 2 issues at the next word.
- **Store rotation (the store rotator):** beat 1 writes `rs2_data << (8*o)` with strobe `ls_size_mask << o`; beat 2 writes `rs2_data >> (8*ls_tail_size)`

with strobe `ls_head_strobe` (a head-size decode: 0/1/2/3/4 bytes → `0000`/`0001`/`0011`/`0111`/`1111`).

- **Load rotation (the load rotator):** beat 1 captures `ls_rdata_lo <= dmem_rdata >> (8*o)`; beat 2 assembles `(dmem_rdata & ls_head_mask) << (8*ls_tail_size) | (ls_rdata_lo & ls_tail_mask)`. Single-beat loads use `(dmem_rdata >> (8*o)) & ls_data_mask`.
- **Size/sign select:** `ls_load_data` from `ls_raw_rdata` per `funct3`: LB sign-extends from bit 7, LBU zero-extends, LH/LHU from bit 15, LW passes through.

`dmem_wstrb = ls_store ? (ls_second ? ls_head_strobe : ls_size_mask << o) : 4'b0000`. Bytes that would rotate past bit 31 on beat 1 are dropped by construction — beat 2 carries them. Full cycle-level behavior and the waveform are in Chapter 4.

4.3.7 Halt and PC Registers

The halt path (`halt_q`, `misalign_target`, `halt_cause_eff`, `halt_now`) and the PC register (`pc <= halt ? pc : (ls_first ? pc : next_pc)`) with the retry/merge/counter flops complete the state. Their behavior is specified in Chapter 4.

Last Updated: 2026-10-07

RTL Design Sherpa · Learning Hardware Design Through Practice GitHub · Documentation Index · MIT License

---

5 kestrel_decode

5.1 Purpose

`kestrel_decode` is a pure function from the 32-bit instruction word to the control bundle. It holds no state and no clock; the same word always produces the same bundle. The bundle's thirteen fields:

The thirteen decode outputs

Field	Type	Meaning when set / value
`alu_op`	`alu_op_e`	ALU operation: ADD SUB AND OR XOR SLL SRL SRA SLT SLTU
`imm_sel`	`imm_sel_e`	Immediate format to build: I S B U J
`alu_src_a_pc`	bit	ALU left input is the PC (else rs1)
`alu_src_b_imm`	bit	ALU right input is the immediate (else rs2)
`rd_wen`	bit	The instruction writes rd this cycle
`dmem_req`	bit	A data-memory access is in flight
`dmem_we`	bit	The access is a store (else a load)
`dmem_size`	2 bits	Access size: `00` byte, `01` halfword, `10` word
`branch`	bit	Instruction is a conditional branch
`jump`	bit	Instruction is JAL
`jalr`	bit	Instruction is JALR
`halt_cause`	4 bits	Halt encoding from `kestrel_pkg`; `HALT_NONE` when running
`csr_stub`	bit	SYSTEM CSR class: writeback a hard zero

5.2 Keying and Defaults

The truth table is a single `unique casez` keyed on `{opcode, funct3, funct7}` — a 17-bit key. Every RV32I instruction is distinguished by those three fields alone; the SYSTEM privileged row re-cases on `insn[31:20]` (imm12) to split ECALL/EBREAK/MRET from illegal encodings. Fields that carry immediate bits are keyed as don't-cares (`F7_DC = 7'b???????`) for OP-IMM arithmetic, loads, stores, and branches; the shift rows key funct7 fully, which is what makes mis-encoded shifts illegal rather than silently executed.

Before the case, decode assigns a default bundle: `alu_op = ADD`, `imm_sel = I`, every control bit clear, `halt_cause = HALT_NONE`. Each row then sets only what it needs. The `default:` row changes exactly one field, `halt_cause = HALT_ILL` — the entire illegal-instruction mechanism. Every encoding not claimed by a row halts, loudly, instead of executing as something plausible.

5.3 The Decode Table

Transcribed row for row from `rtl/fub/kestrel_decode.sv`. The key column is the 17-bit casez key written as `opcode.funct3.funct7`; `any` marks a don't-care key field. Bundle columns show only non-default values; `alu` is `alu_op`, `imm` is `imm_sel`, `aPC` is `alu_src_a_pc`, `bImm` is `alu_src_b_imm`, `rd` is `rd_wen`; `dmem` reports `req`, `+we`, and size in bytes (B/H/W); – means the default.

5.3.1 Arithmetic and upper-immediate rows

The ALU computes datapath arithmetic here; for LUI the writeback mux bypasses the ALU and takes the immediate directly.

Decode rows — OP, OP-IMM, LUI, AUIPC

opcode.funct3.funct7 (17-bit casez key)	Row	alu	imm	aPC	bImm	rd
0110011.000.0000000	ADD	ADD	—	—	—	1
0110011.000.0100000	SUB	SUB	—	—	—	1
0110011.001.0000000	SLL	SLL	—	—	—	1
0110011.010.0000000	SLT	SLT	—	—	—	1
0110011.011.0000000	SLTU	SLTU	—	—	—	1
0110011.100.0000000	XOR	XOR	—	—	—	1
0110011.101.0000000	SRL	SRL	—	—	—	1
0110011.101.0100000	SRA	SRA	—	—	—	1
0110011.110.0000000	OR	OR	—	—	—	1
0110011.111.0000000	AND	AND	—	—	—	1
0010011.000.any	ADDI	ADD	I	—	1	1
0010011.010.any	SLTI	SLT	I	—	1	1
0010011.011.any	SLT	SLT	I	—	1	1

opcode.funct3.funct7 (17-bit casez key)	Row	alu	imm	aPC	bImm	rd
	IU	U				
0010011.100.any	XORI	XOR	I	—	1	1
0010011.110.any	ORI	OR	I	—	1	1
0010011.111.any	ANDI	AND	I	—	1	1
0010011.001.0000000	SLLI	SLL	I	—	1	1
0010011.101.0000000	SRLI	SRL	I	—	1	1
0010011.101.0100000	SRAI	SRA	I	—	1	1
0110111.any.any	LUI	ADD	U	—	1	1
0010111.any.any	AUIPC	ADD	U	1	1	1

5.3.2 Loads, stores, branches, jumps

Every branch/jump row uses `alu = ADD` so the ALU produces `pc + imm` for the next-PC mux while the dedicated comparator decides taken-ness in parallel. JALR is the one jump whose ALU left input is rs1, not PC.

Decode rows — LOAD, STORE, BRANCH, JAL, JALR

opcode.funct3.funct7 (17-bit casez key)	Row	imm	aPC	bImm	dmem	ctl
0000011.000.any	LB	I	—	1	req, B	—
0000011.001.any	LH	I	—	1	req, H	—
0000011.010.any	LW	I	—	1	req, W	—
0000011.100.any	LBU	I	—	1	req, B	—

opcode.funct3.funct7 (17-bit casez key)	Row	imm	aPC	bImm	dmem	ctl
0000011.101.any	LHU	I	—	1	req, H	—
0100011.000.any	SB	S	—	1	req+we, B	—
0100011.001.any	SH	S	—	1	req+we, H	—
0100011.010.any	SW	S	—	1	req+we, W	—
1100011.000.any	BEQ	B	1	1	—	branch
1100011.001.any	BNE	B	1	1	—	branch
1100011.100.any	BLT	B	1	1	—	branch
1100011.101.any	BGE	B	1	1	—	branch
1100011.110.any	BLTU	B	1	1	—	branch
1100011.111.any	BGEU	B	1	1	—	branch
1101111.any.any	JAL	J	1	1	—	jump
1100111.000.any	JALR	I	—	1	—	jalr

5.3.3 System, fence, and the default

Decode rows — SYSTEM, MISC-MEM, and the illegal default

opcode	funct3	imm12	Row	Behavior (how the row retires)	halt_cause
1110011	000	000	ECAL	halt; RVFI trap beat	`4'h1`

opcode	funct3	imm12	Row	Behavior (how the row retires)	halt_cause
			L		
1110011	000	001	EBREAK	halt; RVFI trap beat	4'h2
1110011	000	302	MRET	retire as NOP, pc+4 fall-through	—
1110011	000	other	—	illegal	4'hF
1110011	001/010/011/101/110/111	any	CSRRW/S/C + imm forms	csr_stub: zero readback, writes dropped	—
1110011	100	any	—	reserved, illegal	4'hF
0001111	000	any	FENCE	retire as NOP	—
0001111	001	any	FENCE.I	retire as NOP	—
0001111	010-111	any	—	reserved, illegal	4'hF
any unclaimed	—	—	default	illegal instruction	4'hF

5.4 What the Table Teaches

Three design rulings visible in the table deserve explicit mention:

1. **Reserved encodings halt rather than guess.** Branch funct3 010/011, load/store funct3 011 and 110/111, MISC-MEM funct3 2-7, SYSTEM funct3 100, shift funct7 mismatches: all illegal (unpriv §§2.1.4, 2.1.6 reserve these). A reserved encoding today may become an instruction tomorrow; silently executing it is how compatibility bugs are born.
2. **The CSR class is one stub row-set, not six special cases.** All six Zicsr forms share `csr_stub = 1; rd_wen = 1` and nothing else; the writeback mux owns the zero. The table stays small because the stub is honest about there being nothing to decode.
3. **Cause 3 appears nowhere in this table.** `HALT_IALIGN` is raised only in `kestrel_core`, which can see the resolved next PC and the branch decision. Decode provably cannot know — a branch's target alignment depends on the register operands it never evaluates.

Last Updated: 2026-10-07

RTL Design Sherpa · Learning Hardware Design Through Practice GitHub · Documentation Index · MIT License

---

6 kestrel_imm_gen

6.1 Purpose

`kestrel_imm_gen` builds the 32-bit sign- or zero-extended immediate for the five RV32I instruction formats, selected by `imm_sel` from the control bundle. It is pure combinational logic — a five-row case on bit fields of `insn`.

6.2 Interface

kestrel_imm_gen interface

Port	Direction	Width	Description
`insn`	Input	32	The instruction word (only immediate-bearing bits are used)
`sel`	Input	`imm_sel_e`	Format select from decode: I S B U J
`imm`	Output	32	The assembled immediate

6.3 Internal Structure

The immediate assembly follows the ISA's format definitions exactly (unpriv §2.1):

Immediate assembly per format

sel	Assembly	Formats using it
I	`{{20{insn[31]}}, insn[31:20]}`	ADDI/SLTI/SLTIU/XORI/ORI/ANDI, loads, JALR
S	`{{20{insn[31]}}, insn[31:25], insn[11:7]}`	stores
B	`{{20{insn[31]}}, insn[7], insn[30:25], insn[11:8], 1'b0}`	branches
U	`{insn[31:12], 12'b0}`	LUI, AUIPC
J	`{{12{insn[31]}}, insn[19:12], insn[20], insn[30:21], 1'b0}`	JAL

Notes for maintainers:

- B and J immediates append the implicit low zero (unpriv §2.1) in logic; no consumer may re-shift.
- U is zero-extended by construction (no sign bits) — LUI writes it directly, AUIPC adds it to the PC.
- SLTIU's famously surprising semantics (compare against the *sign-extended* immediate interpreted unsigned, unpriv §2.1.4.1) require no special handling here: the immediate is the same sign-extended value every I-format consumer gets; the ALU's unsigned less-than on it preserves the surprise exactly.

Last Updated: 2026-10-07

7 kestrel_alu

7.1 Purpose

`kestrel_alu` performs the datapath arithmetic for the core: ten operations selected by `alu_op`, operating on the source-mux outputs. It also computes `eq/lt/ltu` flags — which the core deliberately does not use for branches (see the ruling below).

7.2 Interface

kestrel_alu interface

Port	Direction	Width	Description
`op`	Input	`alu_op_e`	Operation select
`a`	Input	32	Left operand (PC or rs1, via the core's source mux)
`b`	Input	32	Right operand (immediate or rs2)
`y`	Output	32	Result
`eq` / `lt` / `ltu`	Output	1 / 1 / 1	Flags: equality, signed less-than, unsigned less-than — unconnected at the core instance

7.3 Operations

ALU operations (`shamt = b[4:0]`)

alu_op	y	Notes
ADD	`a + b`	Also computes branch/JAL targets when `a = pc`
SUB	`a - b`	
AND / OR / XOR	bitwise	
SLL	`a << shamt`	shamt = `b[4:0]` (unpriv §2.1.4.1: shift amounts use 5 bits)
SRL	`a >> shamt`	logical
SRA	`$signed(a) >>> shamt`	arithmetic
SLT	`{{31{1'b0}}, lt}`	sets rd to 0/1
SLTU	`{{31{1'b0}}, ltu}`	unsigned compare, notably for SLTIU's sign-extended-then-unsigned immediate

The shift-by-`b[4:0]` matches the ISA's shamt semantics exactly — and because the decode table keys SLLI/SRLI/SRAI fully on funct7, encodings with shamt[5] set (reserved in RV32I) never reach this module as shifts; they halt as illegal in decode.

7.4 The Flags Ruling

The flags compare `a` against `b`: `eq = (a == b)`, `lt = ($signed(a) < $signed(b))`, `ltu = (a < b)`. For branch instructions the core drives `a = pc` (the ALU is simultaneously computing `pc + imm`), so these flags would compare pc against imm — silently wrong. The core's instance leaves `eq/lt/ltu` unconnected and branches decide on the dedicated rs1/rs2 comparator in the top. The ALU flags remain correct for SLT/SLTU's internal use (`lt`/`ltu` feed the SLT/SLTU rows) and are available to any future consumer whose `a`/`b` are the intended operands. This was a reviewed ruling (Task 4 review, SDD ledger), recorded here so nobody "fixes" the dangling pins.

Last Updated: 2026-10-07

RTL Design Sherpa · Learning Hardware Design Through Practice GitHub · Documentation Index · MIT License

---

8 kestrel_regfile

8.1 Purpose

`kestrel_regfile` is the 32 x 32-bit general-purpose register file: two combinational read ports, one synchronous write port, and the architectural x0 rule enforced in hardware. Reads are combinational because the single-cycle design cannot afford a read latency; the write commits on the clock edge.

8.2 Interface

kestrel_regfile interface

Port	Direction	Width	Description
`clk` / `rst_n`	Input	1 / 1	Clock; active-low reset clears all 32 entries
`rs1_addr` / `rs1_data`	Input / Output	5 / 32	Read port 1 (combinationally `regs[rs1_addr]`)
`rs2_addr` / `rs2_data`	Input / Output	5 / 32	Read port 2
`rd_addr` / `rd_data` / `rd_wen`	Input / Input / Input	5 / 32 / 1	Write port; committed on the edge when `rd_wen` and `rd_addr != 0`

8.3 Internal Structure and Rules

- Storage is `logic [31:0] regs [32]`, reset to all zeros (so no register carries architectural garbage out of reset, and pre-load observability is deterministic).
- **The x0 rule lives here:** writes with `rd_addr == 0` are discarded by the write condition `rd_wen && (rd_addr != X0_ADDR)`; reads of x0 return the reset/stored zero naturally.
- The core additionally gates `rd_wen` (into `rd_wen_eff`) so that the retry's first beat and halted cycles never reach this port — see the kestrel_core chapter.
- No write-forwarding exists: a write commits on the edge and is readable the next cycle. This is exactly the single-cycle contract (a store is visible to the next cycle's load *through the memory*; a register write is visible to the next instruction *through the register file*).

Last Updated: 2026-10-07

RTL Design Sherpa · Learning Hardware Design Through Practice GitHub · Documentation Index · MIT License

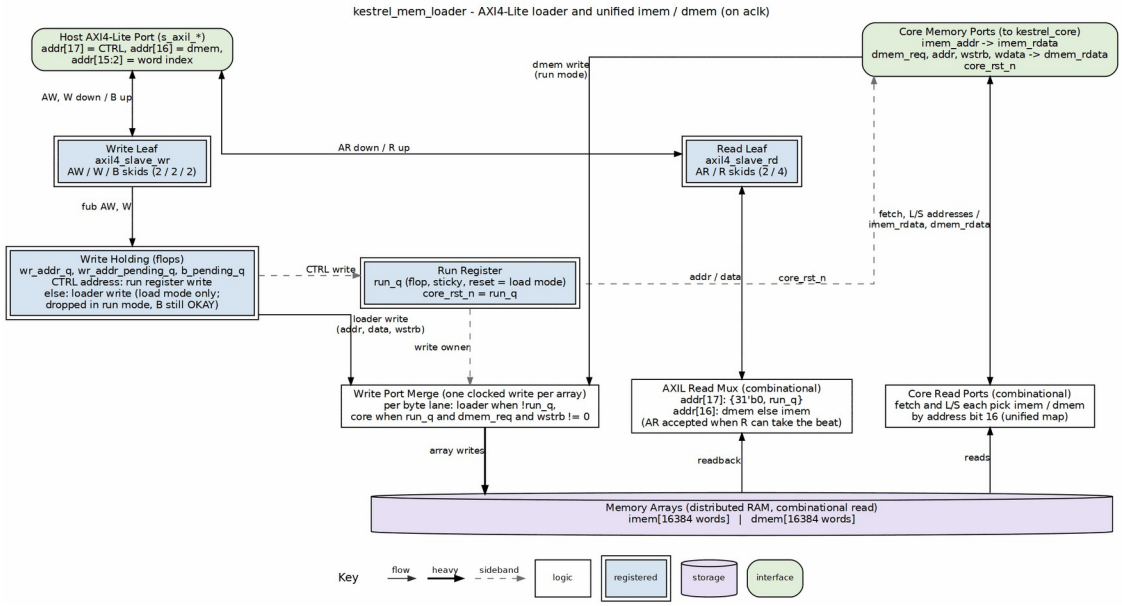
---

9 kestrel_mem_loader

9.1 Purpose

`kestrel_mem_loader` is the optional board glue (HAS Ch. 4 specifies its external contract; this section covers how it is built). It contains: two 16384-word distributed-RAM arrays (`imem`, `dmem`), a CTRL/run register, and the write-port merge logic — wrapped in the repo's skid-buffered AXIL leaf slaves, composed exactly as `rtl/amba/shared/sdpram_slave_axil_axil.sv` composes them. Mutual exclusion between loader and core is by protocol; there is no contention arbiter and no FSM in the datapath.

9.1.1 Figure 2.1: Loader composition



kestrel_mem_loader internal composition

9.2 Memory Arrays

- `(* ram_style = "distributed" *) logic [31:0] imem [0:MEM_WORDS-1]` (and `dmem`) — the attribute keeps reads combinational, which the single-cycle contract requires; a block RAM's synchronous read would break it.
- One write port each, merging two clients per byte lane in a single clocked process: the loader (`ld_wr_*`, gated by `!run_q`) and the core (`core_wr_*`, gated by `run_q && dmem_req && dmem_wstrb != 0`). Both are additionally fenced during reset assertion.
- Under the unified map each array carries up to three combinational read ports (core fetch, core L/S, AXIL readback); distributed-RAM read replication absorbs that in synthesis.
- Power-up content is undefined in hardware; the simulation model zero-initializes so pre-load reads are deterministic. An image is always loaded before run.

9.3 CTRL / Run Register and Reset Sequencing

`run_q` is a sticky bit (set by a CTRL write with `wstrb[0] & wdata[0]`, cleared only by reset). `core_rst_n` is literally `run_q`: low in load mode (the core is held, parks its fetch at `RESET_ADDR`, retires nothing), high from the commit cycle of the run write. Power-on default is load mode.

9.4 Write Side: Leaf Slave plus Two Holding Bits

The `axil4_slave_wr` leaf terminates the AW/W/B protocol into FUB nets. The wrapper's entire write-side state is two holding bits plus the run register:

- `wr_addr_q` / `wr_addr_pending_q`: the AW address holds until its W beat fires (`fub_awready = !wr_addr_pending_q || w_fire`; a same-cycle swap lets a new AW in as the old W fires).
- `b_pending_q`: at most one B outstanding (`fub_wready = wr_addr_pending_q && !b_pending_q`); B returns OKAY one holding bit deep and the leaf's B skid buffers it against the master.

Loader-write qualification: `ld_wr_fire = w_fire && !wr_addr_q[CTRL_BIT] && !run_q` — memory writes land only in load mode; CTRL writes never touch the arrays. Run-mode loader writes are dropped in logic with B still OKAY (testplan scenario ML-09).

9.5 Read Side: Combinational Beat through the AR Skid

The `axil4_slave_rd` leaf supplies the AR/R handshake; the wrapper's response is a single-cycle combinational beat: `fub_arready = fub_rready` (AR accepted exactly when the R skid can take the beat), `fub_rvalid = fub_arvalid`, `fub_rresp = OKAY`. The read mux is:

```
fub_rdata = fub_araddr[CTRL_BIT] ? {31'b0, run_q}
          : fub_araddr[DMEM_BIT] ? dmem[fub_araddr[WORD_IDX_W-1:0]]
          :                        imem[fub_araddr[WORD_IDX_W-1:0]];
```

Core-side reads select the array the same way: `imem_rdata = imem_addr[DMEM_BIT] ? dmem[imem_addr[13:0]] : imem[imem_addr[13:0]]` (and likewise for `dmem_rdata`), which is what makes one flat image coherent across fetch, L/S, and AXIL readback.

9.6 Address Map, as Implemented

Loader map implementation facts

Item	Implementation
Array word index	`addr[13:0]` of the presenting port's byte address (`WORD_IDX_W = $clog2(MEM_WORDS) = 14`), AXIL and core alike
Array select	`addr[16]`: 0 = imem, 1 = dmem, on every port (unified map)
CTRL decode	`addr[17] = 1` → CTRL register at `0x0002_0000`

Two consequences the maintainer must not "tidy" without a plan-level decision: byte-address bits [15:14] are not decoded, so each region's 64 KB byte window aliases onto its array every `0x4000` bytes; and because the core presents only word-aligned addresses, its window is the 4096 word-aligned slots (16 KB of image) per array — the delivery testbench streams word *k* to AXIL byte address 4*k, which is the convention that keeps loader and core views identical. The module header's `addr[15:2]` wording describes intent; the implemented `addr[13:0]` slice above is the as-built truth this specification documents.

9.7 Debug Taps

`o_dbg_busy_wr` / `o_dbg_busy_rd` are the leaf slaves' busy outputs, exposed for the AXIL backpressure checks (scenario ML-08).

Last Updated: 2026-10-07

RTL Design Sherpa · Learning Hardware Design Through Practice GitHub · Documentation Index · MIT License

---

10 Package Types and Top-Level Wiring

10.1 kestrel_pkg

`kestrel_pkg` (`rtl/includes/kestrel_pkg.sv`) is the shared type and encoding source. It contains no state and no modules; every kestrel filelist pulls it in with `-f`, and consumers never name the package path directly.

10.1.1 ALU operation enum (`alu_op_e`, 4 bits)

`alu_op_e` enumerators

Enumerator	Operation
`ADD SUB`	add / subtract
`AND OR XOR`	bitwise
`SLL SRL SRA`	shifts (shamt = `b[4:0]`)
`SLT SLTU`	set-less-than, signed / unsigned

10.1.2 Immediate-format enum (`imm_sel_e`, 3 bits)

`imm_sel_e` enumerators

Enumerator	Format	Assembly
`I`	I-type	`{{20{insn[31]}}, insn[31:20]}`
`S`	S-type	`{{20{insn[31]}}, insn[31:25], insn[11:7]}`
`B`	B-type	`{{20{insn[31]}}, insn[7], insn[30:25], insn[11:8], 1'b0}`
`U`	U-type	`{insn[31:12], 12'b0}`
`J`	J-type	`{{12{insn[31]}}, insn[19:12], insn[20], insn[30:21], 1'b0}`

10.1.3 Halt-cause encodings (`localparam logic [3:0]`)

`HALT_*` encodings — the single source of truth shared by decode and core

Name	Value	Raised in	Meaning
`HALT_NONE`	`4'h0`	—	running
`HALT_ECALL`	`4'h1`	`kestrel_decode`	ECALL

Name	Value	Raised in	Meaning
HALT_EBREAK	4'h2	kestrel_decode	EBREAK
HALT_IALIGN	4'h3	kestrel_core	taken control transfer to a non-4-aligned target
HALT_ILL	4'hF	kestrel_decode	illegal encoding (default row)

The package comment records the ownership split: causes 1, 2, and F belong to decode; cause 3 belongs to the core because the condition needs the resolved next PC and branch decision that decode cannot see.

10.2 Top-Level Wiring (kestrel_core)

The instance map every maintainer should be able to redraw from memory:

kestrel_core internal wiring map

Net(s)	Driver → Load	Notes
`insn = imem_rdata`	fetch → decode, imm_gen, regfile addrs, RVFI	`opcode = insn[6:0]`, `funct3 = insn[14:12]`
Control bundle (13)	`u_decode` → muxes, regfile, L/S datapath	keyed on `{opcode, funct3, funct7}`
`imm`	`u_imm_gen` → `alu_src_b` mux, writeback (LUI)	
`rs1_data` / `rs2_data`	`u_regfile` → source muxes, comparator, store-data rotators	read addrs from `insn[19:15]` / `insn[24:20]`
`alu_y`	`u_alu` → dmem address, writeback mux	ALU flags unconnected (ruling, kestrel_alu chapter)
`cmp_eq`/`cmp_lt`/ `cmp_ltu` → `branch_cond` → `branch_taken`	core comparator → next-PC mux	funct3 selects the condition
`next_pc`	next-PC mux → PC register, `rvfi_pc_wdata`	4-row priority mux
`rd_wdata` / `rd_wen_eff`	writeback mux + gates → `u_regfile`	x0 discard inside the file
L/S nets (`ls_*`, `dmem_*`)	core rotators → dmem pins	retry state `ls_retry`, merge register `ls_rdata_lo`
Halt nets (`halt_*`, `misalign_target`)	core → halt ports, `halt_q`	`halt_cause_eff = dec_halt_cause`

Net(s)	Driver → Load	Notes
		`| (misalign_target ? HALT_IALIGN : HALT_NONE)`
RVFI bundle (17)	core aggregation assigns → top ports	rules in Chapter 4

10.3 Reset Discipline

All sequential logic uses the shared `reset_defs.svh` macros (`ALWAYS_FF_RST`, `RST_ASSERTED`): asynchronous assert, synchronous deassert, active-low `rst_n`. The register file clears to zeros; the PC clears to `RESET_ADDR`; `halt_q`, `ls_retry`, `ls_rdata_lo`, and `retire_count` clear to zero. The loader applies the same macros with `aresetn`, and its `core_rst_n` output is the core's actual reset in loader integrations.

Last Updated: 2026-10-07

RTL Design Sherpa · Learning Hardware Design Through Practice GitHub · Documentation Index · MIT License

---

11 The Single Cycle, Step by Step

11.1 The Clock in One Sentence

On every rising edge, kestrel writes one register-file entry (maybe), updates the PC (unless held), and moves its bookkeeping flops — while a combinational cloud standing between `pc` and the next edge computes everything the next cycle needs: the fetched instruction, its decode, the operands, the result, the memory access, the next PC, and the RVFI record for whatever retires this cycle.

The sections below follow the data in dependency order through a fully general cycle.

11.2 1. Fetch and Decode

`imem_addr = pc` and `insn = imem_rdata` — the instruction memory answers in the same cycle. Decode is the truth table of the kestrel_decode chapter, producing the thirteen-field control bundle plus defaults of “no operation, no halt.”

11.3 2. Operands and Immediates

The register file reads `rs1 = insn[19:15]` and `rs2 = insn[24:20]` combinationally; x0 reads zero because the file ties it. The immediate generator builds one of the five format immediates under `imm_sel`. Two muxes select the ALU inputs: `alu_src_a` is the PC (for AUIPC and branch targets) or `rs1_data`; `alu_src_b` is the immediate or `rs2_data`.

11.4 3. Execute

The ALU computes one of ten operations. For branches, the dedicated comparator evaluates `cmp_eq/cmp_lt/cmp_ltu` on `rs1_data`/`rs2_data` in parallel, with funct3 selecting the condition in a `unique case`. Both the ALU's target (`pc + imm`, since `alu_src_a = pc` on branch rows) and the taken decision are ready when the next PC is chosen — taken and not-taken branches cost the same cycle.

11.5 4. Memory Access

For loads and stores, `dmem_addr` is the word-aligned ALU result (`{alu_y[31:2], 2'b00}` — or the next word on a retry beat), `dmem_wdata`/`dmem_wstrb` are the rotated store data and byte enables, and read data is rotated back before size/sign selection implements LB/LBU/LH/LHU/LW. Aligned and in-word-misaligned accesses complete in this one cycle; a cross-word access holds the PC for a retry cycle and issues a second beat (next section).

11.6 5. Writeback

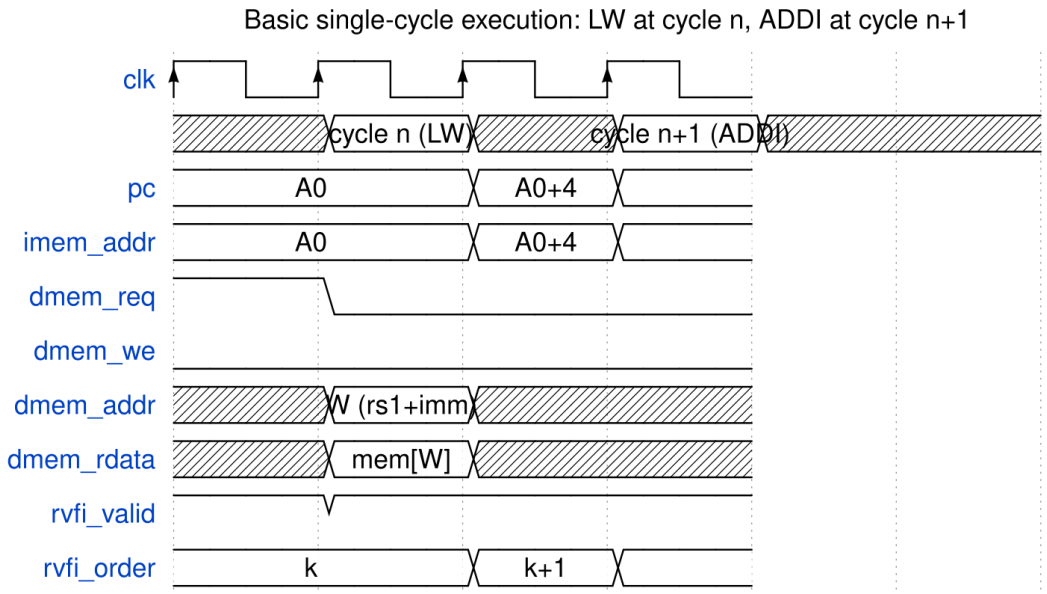
`rd_wdata` is selected by the five-row priority mux (CSR stub zero → LUI immediate → load data → link `pc+4` → ALU result); `rd_wen_eff = rd_wen & ~ls_first & ~halt` qualifies it; the write commits on the edge.

11.7 6. Next-PC Selection and the Edge

The next-PC mux selects among JAL/JALR target, taken-branch target, and `pc + 4`. The PC register loads `next_pc` on the edge — unless `halt` (frozen) or `ls_first` (held for the retry beat). `rvfi_pc_wdata = next_pc` reports the architecturally next PC on the retire beat.

11.8 The Basic Cycle on the Pins

11.8.1 Waveform 4.1: Basic single-cycle execution — an aligned load followed by an ALU op



Waveform 4.1: basic single-cycle execution — an aligned load followed by an ALU op

Two back-to-back retiring instructions. During cycle *n* the LW's full path — imem read, decode, register read, ALU address, dmem read, rotate/sign-extend, writeback mux — completes between the same two edges, and the beat retires (`rvfi_valid=1`) with the load's memory fields. The ADDI in cycle *n+1* retires just the same: CPI 1 with no bubbles, because the whole machine is combinational between the PC and the edge.

11.9 Branch and Jump Resolution

Control-transfer resolution

Transfer	Target computation	Decision source	Cost
BEQ/BNE/ BLT/BGE/ BLTU/BGEU	`pc + imm(B)` — ALU row `alu_src_a_pc=1`	dedicated comparator, funct3-selected	1 cycle, taken or not
JAL	`pc + imm(J)`	unconditional (`jump=1`)	1 cycle
JALR	`(rs1_data + imm) & 32'hFFFF_FFFE`	unconditional (`jalr=1`)	1 cycle
Taken transfer to `next_pc[1:0] != 00`	computed but not committed	`misalign_target` → halt cause `0x3`	halts (next section)

Last Updated: 2026-10-07

RTL Design Sherpa · Learning Hardware Design Through Practice GitHub · Documentation Index · MIT License

12 Cross-Word Misaligned Retry

12.1 When the Retry Fires

The L/S datapath completes any access with `addr[1:0] + size <= 4` in the single cycle — every aligned access and every misaligned access that stays inside one word. When `addr[1:0] + size > 4` the access straddles two words, one 32-bit beat cannot carry it, and the retry machinery engages:

- `ls_crossing = ls_active & ((ls_offset + ls_size_bytes) > 4)`
- `ls_first = ls_crossing & ~ls_retry` — the first beat is in flight
- `ls_second = ls_retry` — the retry beat
- `ls_retry <= ls_first` — one bit of control state; no FSM

12.2 Beat-by-Beat Behavior

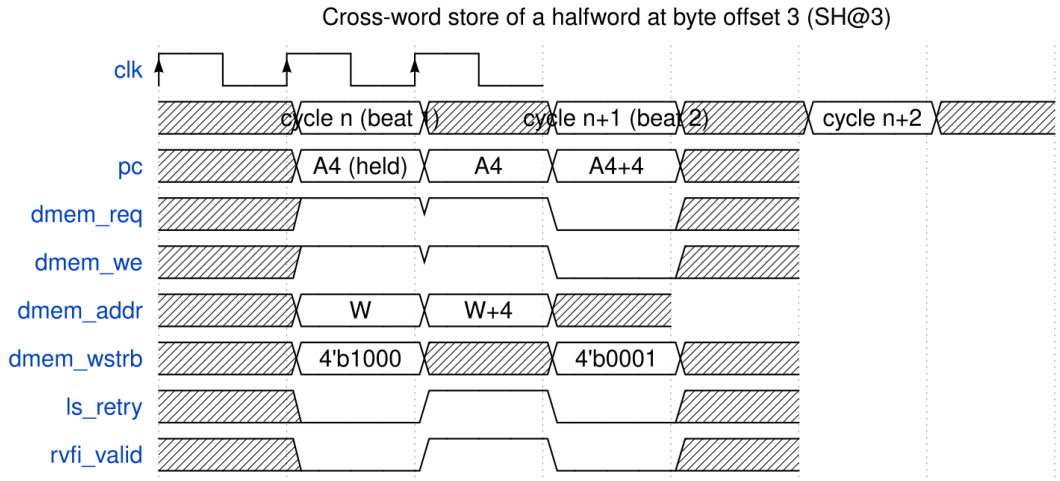
The two beats of a cross-word access (o = `addr[1:0]`)

Aspect	Beat 1 (`ls_first`)	Beat 2 (`ls_second`)
`dmem_addr`	`{alu_y[31:2], 2'b00}` — word containing the start	`{alu_y[31:2] + 1, 2'b00}` — the next word
Store data	`rs2_data << (8*o)`	`rs2_data >> (8*(4-o))`
Store strobe	`size_mask << o` (tail bytes)	`ls_head_strobe` (head bytes only)
Load path	`ls_rdata_lo <= dmem_rdata >> (8*o)`	`ls_raw_rdata = (dmem_rdata & head_mask) << (8*(4-o)) | (ls_rdata_lo & tail_mask)`
PC	held (`pc <= ls_first ? pc : next_pc`)	advances on the edge
`rvfi_valid`	low — no partial beat leaks	high — the access retires once, with assembled data

Everything else in the core is unaware the retry happened: `dmem_req` (and `dmem_we` for stores) simply stays high across both beats while the address steps by one word.

12.3 The Waveform

12.3.1 Waveform 4.2: Cross-word store retry — SH at byte offset 3



Waveform 4.2: cross-word store retry — SH at byte offset 3

A store-halfword at byte offset 3 (the SH@3 case): beat 1 writes the tail byte of word W with strobe `4'b1000`; beat 2 writes the head byte of word W+4 with strobe `4'b0001`, data right-rotated by the tail size. `dmem_req`/`dmem_we` stay high across both beats, `ls_retry` marks the retry cycle, the PC holds for one extra cycle, and the instruction retires exactly once — `rvfi_valid` high only on the final cycle.

12.4 Worked Example: a Halfword Across the Boundary

`lh x2, 7(x10)` with x10 = 0x1000 reads the halfword at 0x1007 — one byte at offset 3 of word 0x1000 and one at offset 0 of word 0x1004.

- Beat 1: `dmem_addr = 0x1000`, read data `>> 24`, captured into `ls_rdata_lo` — the tail byte.
- Beat 2: `dmem_addr = 0x1004`, head byte merged at bits [15:8]; the halfword is sign-extended from bit 15 into x2.
- RVFI: one beat, `mem_addr = 0x1007`, `rmask = 0011` packed from the addressed address, `mem_rdata` holding the assembled halfword in bits [15:0].

A directed test with distinct nonzero bytes on both sides of the boundary (`ls_misaligned`) pins this end to end; a first-cut implementation that silently truncated bytes rotating past bit 31 reported `0x00FE` where the architectural answer was `0xCAFE` — caught because the golden interpreter models the full two-word semantics and the lockstep diff tolerates no slop.

12.5 Why Hardware, Why Two Cycles

Trapping to software emulation needs the trap machinery kestrel deliberately does not have, and emulating in a trap stub would make the misaligned case a hundred cycles instead of two. Hardware handling keeps every access at fixed cost — one cycle in-word, two crossing — which is the only cost model a single-cycle core can afford to reason about. The price is integration: a misaligned word access performs two word reads/writes and is not atomic, which the spec never promised anyway (unpriv §2.1.6). Instruction-side misalignment is not permitted this latitude — the next section covers the halt.

Last Updated: 2026-10-07

RTL Design Sherpa · Learning Hardware Design Through Practice GitHub · Documentation Index · MIT License

---

13 Halt, IALIGN, and the System Layer

13.1 The Halt Holding Register

`halt_q` is a one-bit flop that latches any nonzero `halt_cause_eff`:

```
halt_cause_eff = dec_halt_cause | (misalign_target ? HALT_IALIGN :
HALT_NONE)
halt_now       = |halt_cause_eff
halt_q         <= halt_q | halt_now
halt           = halt_q | halt_now        // visible on the first
halting cycle
```

Decode raises `HALT_ECALL (1)`, `HALT_EBREAK (2)`, and `HALT_ILL (F)`; the core raises `HALT_IALIGN (3)`. Once latched:

- The PC freezes (`pc <= halt ? pc : ...`).
- Writeback is suppressed (`rd_wen_eff` and the RVFI `rd_wb` gate both use `halt`).
- Retirement stops: `rvfi_valid = rst_n & ~halt_q & ~ls_first`, and since `halt_q` latches on the halting cycle, the halting instruction itself is the last beat — a trap beat with `rvfi_trap = halt_now`.

A holding register rather than a pulse matters for verification: an external observer sampling any time after the halt sees a stable, unambiguous stopped state with the cause still on the port. The testbench samples four post-halt cycles pinning `halt` raised, `rvfi_valid` low, `rvfi_pc_rdata` frozen.

13.2 The IALIGN Halt (Cause 3)

With IALIGN=32 — no compressed instructions — every fetch must be 4-byte aligned, and unpriv §2.1.5 requires an *instruction-address-misaligned* exception when taken control flow targets an address whose low two bits are not `00`. RISC-V's permission to handle *data* misalignment in hardware does not extend here.

The condition, visible only in the core:

```
misalign_target = (jump | jalr | branch_taken) & (next_pc[1:0] != 2'b00)
```

Why decode cannot catch it: for JALR the target depends on a register value; for every branch it depends on the taken decision. Decode sees neither — it produces the control bundle, not the data. `kestrel_pkg` states the ownership directly: cause 3 belongs to the core.

The writeback subtlety. JAL/JALR set decode's `rd_wen` — they are link instructions, and a taken JAL/JALR that *does* align must write `pc+4`. The misaligned case must not. Rather than teaching decode about alignment, the core gates both the register write and the RVFI report with `halt` itself: `rd_wen_eff = rd_wen & ~ls_first & ~halt`, `rd_wb = rd_wen & (insn[11:7] != 0) & ~halt`. The trap beat reports the misaligned target on `rvfi_pc_wdata` (it is `next_pc`), exactly what a real trap would record as the faulting address — a detail riscv-formal's checks verify explicitly.

13.3 The System Layer: Stubs, NOPs, and Halts

The thirty-seven base instructions sit inside two opcode classes that belong to the wider system: MISC-MEM (FENCE and friends, unpriv §2.1.7; FENCE.I is Zifencei, §4.1) and SYSTEM (ECALL, EBREAK, and the Zicsr CSR instructions, §4.2; MRET is defined in the privileged Volume II). kestrel has no memory-ordering hardware, no CSR file, and no trap handler, so these classes retire through documented stubs and NOPs. Exactly what that means — including what it does *not* mean:

13.3.1 FENCE and FENCE.I retire as NOPs

kestrel's imem and dmem are separate, combinational-read ports on a single-cycle core: there is no write buffer to drain, no cache to invalidate, no instruction prefetch to refetch. Fence semantics are vacuous at this rung, and decode retires FENCE (MISC-MEM funct3 000) and FENCE.I (funct3 001) as NOPs — one cycle each, no architectural effect. MISC-MEM funct3 2-7 are reserved and halt as illegal. (The one battery test whose program modifies its own instruction stream, `rv32ui-p-fence_i`, works because the *testbench memory* is a single unified array serving both ports — a testbench coherence choice, not a core feature.)

13.3.2 MRET falls through

MRET (SYSTEM funct3 000, imm12 `0x302`) returns from a machine trap. It is meaningful only when traps exist — trap state, `mepc`, privilege transfers, all rung-3 machinery. kestrel retires MRET as a documented NOP-with-fall-through: the PC advances to pc+4. That choice is not arbitrary: the riscv-tests p-environment points `mepc` at the instruction following its trap stub in the configurations kestrel runs, so pc+4 is exactly what the test expects. This is stated plainly so nobody mistakes it for trap support.

13.3.3 The CSR class retires as a bounded stub

The six Zicsr forms (SYSTEM funct3 001/010/011/101/110/111) retire through `csr_stub`: decode raises `csr_stub` and `rd_wen`, and the writeback mux substitutes a hard zero. Reads return zero; writes drop on the floor. SYSTEM funct3 100 is reserved and halts as illegal.

Say it plainly: **this is not CSR support.** There is no CSR file, no `mstatus`, no `mtvec`, no counters, and nothing the instructions do has architectural effect beyond a zero written to rd. The stub exists for one bounded reason: the riscv-tests p-environment preamble executes about a dozen CSR instructions plus an MRET before every test body, and without the stub the battery cannot run at all. On the battery programs the only CSR read with rd != x0 is `mhartid` (value 0), which the stub matches. Anything needing real CSR state — trap handlers, counters, feature probing — is out of contract at this rung and fails loudly either as a zero where a nonzero was expected or as a program that halts where it should have trapped. The honesty matters for the ladder: merlin inherits the same stub, and peregrine replaces it with a real machine-mode CSR file. The seam is deliberately visible in the decode table.

13.4 Halt Timing Summary

Halt timing at the boundary

Cycle	`halt`	`rvfi_valid`	`rvfi_trap`	PC	Notes
Last running cycle	0	1	0	advances	normal retirement
Halting cycle	1 (immediate)	1	1	frozen from this edge	trap beat; cause on `halt_cause`; no rd/mem fields
All later cycles	1	0	0	frozen	`halt_q` holds; cause held on the port

Last Updated: 2026-10-07

RTL Design Sherpa · Learning Hardware Design Through Practice GitHub · Documentation Index · MIT License

---

14 RVFI Aggregation

14.1 Retirement as the Observation Channel

Every instruction that retires produces one beat; the halting instruction produces one final trap beat; nothing else produces anything. The cocotb testbench diffs these beats field by field against a golden interpreter, and riscv-formal relates them to an instruction-set model. Both consumers need the aggregation rules below to be exact — they are stated next to the assignments in the RTL and restated here.

14.2 The Field Table

RVFI signals and their kestrel aggregation

Signal	Width	kestrel aggregation
`rvfi_valid`	1	`rst_n & ~halt_q & ~ls_first` — high exactly on retiring cycles
`rvfi_order`	64	`retire_count`; 0, 1, 2, … over retired beats
`rvfi_pc_rdata`	32	The retiring instruction's PC
`rvfi_pc_wdata`	32	`next_pc` — the architecturally next PC (the misaligned target on a cause-3 halt)
`rvfi_insn`	32	The instruction word
`rvfi_trap`	1	`halt_now`: high on the single halting trap beat
`rvfi_rs1_addr` / `rvfi_rs2_addr`	5+5	Register-file read ports (`insn[19:15]`, `insn[24:20]`)
`rvfi_rs1_rdata` / `rvfi_rs2_rdata`	32+32	Read data; x0 reads zero naturally
`rvfi_rd_addr` / `rvfi_rd_wdata`	5+32	Writeback, when `rd_wb`; both zero otherwise
`rvfi_mem_addr`	32	The unaligned byte address of a load/store (`alu_y`); zero otherwise
`rvfi_mem_rmask` / `rvfi_mem_wmask`	4+4	Byte lanes touched, packed from bit 0 relative to `rvfi_mem_addr` (a word access reports `4'b1111` regardless of offset)
`rvfi_mem_rdata` / `rvfi_mem_wdata`	32+32	Assembled access data (loads) / size-truncated store data (`rs2_data & ls_data_mask`); zero otherwise

14.3 The Three Gating Rules

Three qualifications turn the raw datapath signals into a clean retire stream:

1. **x0 reports zero.** `rd_wb = rd_wen & (insn[11:7] != 0) & ~halt`, so a beat writing x0 reports `rd_addr = 0` with `rd_wdata = 0`. This is not merely tidiness: riscv-formal requires `rd_wdata == 0` whenever `rd_addr == 0`, and the early core failed exactly there until the rule was pinned. The register file independently discards the x0 write architecturally.
2. **The retry's first cycle is silent.** During the first beat of a cross-word access, `rvfi_valid` is low (`ls_first` masks it): no partial beat leaks out. The access reports one beat on its final cycle, with the full assembled data.
3. **Halt retires one trap beat, then silence.** `rvfi_trap = halt_now` marks the halting instruction itself — a beat with trap set, no rd write, no memory fields — after which the latched `halt_q` holds `rvfi_valid` low forever. The wrapper used by riscv-formal derives `rvfi_halt = rvfi_valid & halt`, which matches the semantics exactly: the trap beat is the final retirement. (`rvfi_intr = 0`, `rvfi_mode = M`, `rvfi_ixl = 32` are generated in the wrapper, not the core.)

14.4 Memory-Field Packing

For loads and stores, `rvfi_mem_addr` is the *unaligned* byte address and the masks count byte lanes from bit 0 relative to that address — the riscv-formal byte-*i* convention of `rvfi.md`. A store's `rvfi_mem_wdata` is the store value truncated to the access size (`rs2_data & ls_data_mask`), not the raw register; leaking the upper bytes into the payload is a real bug class this encoding exists to prevent, and one kestrel fixed when the battery's ma_data-shaped vectors arrived. For a cross-word access the single retire beat reports the full-size mask with the assembled data — the retry's two physical beats collapse into one architectural record.

14.5 Why This Pays

Because the rules are few and stated in RTL comments next to the assignments, the golden interpreter models the same rules in Python and the two can be diffed beat for beat over tens of thousands of instructions with zero tolerance. When a diff appears, it names the cycle, the PC, and the field — which is how the misaligned-jump defect (found by riscv-formal as a counterexample the 42-test battery missed) was localized in minutes rather than debugged from waveforms.

Last Updated: 2026-10-07

RTL Design Sherpa · Learning Hardware Design Through Practice GitHub · Documentation Index · MIT License

---

15 Verification Hooks and Observability

15.1 The Three Testplan-Tracked Hooks

kestrel was built RVFI-first, and the verification architecture hangs three observable hooks off the boundary. Each maps to committed testplan scenarios:

The three testplan-tracked hooks

Hook	Signals	What it proves	Testplan anchor
RVFI retire channel	17 `rvfi_*` ports	Architectural correctness: every retired beat diffed full-field against the golden interpreter `rv32i_interpreter.py` (pc, insn, order, trap, rs/rd, all four memory channels — no sampled subset, no tolerance); riscv-formal's 42 checks relate the same beats to ISA models	`kestrel_core` CORE-01..CORE-05, CORE-14; `kestrel_mem_loader` ML-07
Halt observability	`halt`, `halt_cause`	Program end, cause classification, and the post-hold: the halting trap beat, then at least four cycles of `halt` raised with `rvfi_valid` low and the PC frozen	`kestrel_core` CORE-12, CORE-13
Data-port watch	`dmem_req`, `dmem_addr`, `dmem_wstrb`, `dmem_wdata`	The memory contract on the pins: rotated strobes land the right bytes (TB per-byte merge), retry addressing steps one word, the tohost mailbox is observed on the store port, store-to-load	`kestrel_core` CORE-08..CORE-11; loader ML-02/ML-05/ML-06

Hook	Signals	What it proves	Testplan anchor
		visibility is single-cycle	

15.2 Supporting Hooks

Supporting loader hooks

Hook	Signals	Use
Loader reset tap	`core_rst_n`	Load-mode isolation: with `rst_n` released but `CTRL.run` still 0, the core is held, its PC parks at `RESET_ADDR`, and loader writes become visible on the core-side read port (ML-04)
Leaf busy taps	`o_dbg_busy_wr`, `o_dbg_busy_rd`	AXIL backpressure: B/R must hold stable under stalled `bready`/`rready` with busy asserted (ML-08)
Run-mode write rejection	AXIL write + readback	A loader write in run mode is dropped in logic with B OKAY — the halted core's ECALL word must not be poisoned (ML-09)

15.3 The Consumer Stack

Verification consumer stack

Layer	Mechanism	Scope
Golden interpreter lockstep	`rv32i_interpreter.py` emits the same RVFI beat format as the core; the cocotb harness diffs full-field, zero tolerance	Every golden-trace test, plus the constrained-random fuzz (5 gate / 25 func / 200 full streams)
Spike lockstep	`spike --isa=RV32I -l` commit stream walked 1:1 against the core's (pc, insn) beats; exception records verified per beat; exit code confirms tohost==1	Battery and fuzz at func level, using the hardware-misaligned spike 1.1.0 build
rv32ui battery	42 self-checking riscv-tests programs run to the ECALL halt; verdict = x3's last writeback	3/3 gate, 42/42 func and full
riscv-formal	42 bounded-model-checking proofs (37 instruction models + reg/pc_fwd/pc_bwd/liveness/uniqueue) against the RVFI port, depth 6, z3/smtbmc	Every RTL change; the gate that caught the misaligned-jump bug 42 directed tests missed

15.4 Cross-Reference to the Testplan Set

The six plans in `dv/testplans/` are the V&V cross-reference for both this MAS and the HAS: `kestrel_core_testplan.yaml` (18 scenarios — ISA classes, branches, loads/stores incl. the cross-word retry, system layer, battery, lockstep, fuzz, coverage closure at 94.9% line), `kestrel_mem_loader_testplan.yaml` (ML-01..ML-09), and per-FUB plans (`kestrel_alu`, `kestrel_decode`, `kestrel_imm_gen`, `kestrel_regfile`) whose directed rows pin each block's unit behavior against the chapters of this document. Coverage closure is measured across all cells (Verilator line coverage through the central cov_utils hook); regenerate with the commands recorded in each plan.

Last Updated: 2026-10-07

RTL Design Sherpa · Learning Hardware Design Through Practice GitHub · Documentation Index · MIT License

---

16 Parameters, Defines, and Filelists

16.1 Parameters

16.1.1 kestrel_core

kestrel_core parameters

Parameter	Type	Default	Verified values	Description
RESET_ADDR	logic [31:0]	32'h0000_0000	0x0, 0x100, 0x8000_0000	Reset fetch address; the first retired beat's pc_rdata equals it (testplan scenario CORE-03)

16.1.2 kestrel_mem_loader

kestrel_mem_loader parameters

Parameter	Type	Default	Description
AXIL_ADDR_WIDTH	int	18	AXIL slave address width; bits [17:0] of the map
AXIL_DATA_WIDTH	int	32	One 32-bit word per beat
MEM_WORDS	int	16384	Words per array (64 KB imem + 64 KB dmem)
SKID_DEPTH_AW / SKID_DEPTH_W / SKID_DEPTH_B	int	2 / 2 / 2	axil4_slave_wr skid depths
SKID_DEPTH_AR / SKID_DEPTH_R	int	2 / 4	axil4_slave_rd skid depths

Only the default loader parameterization is exercised by the testplans (single build config; recorded as verified, no sweep claimed). RESET_ADDR coverage is recorded per value in the core testplan.

16.2 Defines and Includes

Shared defines

Include	Used by	Purpose
`reset_defs.svh` (via `-f $REPO_ROOT/rtl/amba/filelists/reset_defs.f`)	`kestrel_core`, `kestrel_regfile`, `kestrel_mem_loader`	`ALWAYS_FF_RST` / `RST_ASSERTED` macros: asynchronous assert, synchronous deassert, active-low

No `define` configuration surface exists beyond this; there are no feature ifdefs in the kestrel RTL.

16.3 Filelists

Filelists (`KESTREL_ROOT` = `projects/components/riscv-ip/kestrel-rv32i`; `REPO_ROOT` = RTLDesignSherpa checkout root)

Filelist	Contents	Needs
`rtl/filelists/kestrel_pkg.f`	`kestrel_pkg` alone	`$KESTREL_ROOT`
`rtl/filelists/fub/kestrel_alu.f`	ALU + package	`$KESTREL_ROOT`
`rtl/filelists/fub/kestrel_decode.f`	Decode + package	`$KESTREL_ROOT`
`rtl/filelists/fub/kestrel_imm_gen.f`	Immediate generator + package	`$KESTREL_ROOT`
`rtl/filelists/fub/kestrel_regfile.f`	Register file + `reset_defs` + package	`$KESTREL_ROOT`, `$REPO_ROOT`
`rtl/filelists/fub/kestrel_mem_loader.f`	Loader + `reset_defs` + package + `axil4_slave_wr`/`axil4_slave_rd` closures	`$KESTREL_ROOT`, `$REPO_ROOT`
`rtl/filelists/top/kestrel_core.f`	Core top + all core FUB closures	`$KESTREL_ROOT`, `$REPO_ROOT`
`rtl/filelists/kestrel_all.f`	Master closure: everything above	`$KESTREL_ROOT`, `$REPO_ROOT`
`dv/filelists/kestrel_tb.f`	`kestrel_tb_top` + `kestrel_loader_tb_top` on `kestrel_all.f`	`$KESTREL_ROOT`

Compile-order and closure discipline: each list is complete for its module (package, includes, leaf dependencies); `kestrel_all.f` includes everything with `-f` and never hand-lists sources. The filelists are the supported compile interface.

16.4 Regenerating This Document

```
# from projects/components/riscv-ip/kestrel-rv32i/docs
./generate_mas_pdf.sh --rev 0.1     # KESTREL_MAS_v0.1.docx / .pdf
./generate_has_pdf.sh --rev 0.1     # KESTREL_HAS_v0.1.docx / .pdf
python3 gen_kestrel_figures.py      # regenerate figures + waveform
PNGs
```

The block and composition figures are graphviz sources in `kestrel_{has,mas}/assets/graphviz/`, rendered by each directory's `regenerate_all_graphviz.sh`. `gen_kestrel_figures.py` (this directory) copies the falcon-ladder figure and renders the wavedrom sources in `kestrel_mas/assets/wavedrom/*.json` via `wavedrom-cli` + `inkscape`; both build scripts only consume the committed PNGs.

Last Updated: 2026-10-07

RTL Design Sherpa · Learning Hardware Design Through Practice GitHub · Documentation Index · MIT License

---

17 KESTREL-RV32I Hardware Architecture Specification Index

Version: 0.3 **Date:** 2026-10-20 **Purpose:** High-level hardware architecture specification for the kestrel-rv32i single-cycle RV32I core

---

17.1 Document Organization

Note: All chapters linked below for automated document generation.

17.1.1 Front Matter

- Document Information

17.1.2 Chapter 1: Introduction

- Purpose and Scope

17.1.3 Chapter 2: System Overview

- System Overview and Context

17.1.4 Chapter 3: Architecture

- ISA Scope
- Programmer-Visible Machine State

17.1.5 Chapter 4: Interfaces

- kestrel_core Port Specification
- Memory Contract
- Halt and Trap Behavior
- kestrel_mem_loader and AXIL Programming Interface

17.1.6 Chapter 5: Performance

- Performance Characteristics

17.1.7 Chapter 6: Integration

- Integration Guide

17.2 Related Documentation

- **KESTREL MAS** - Micro-Architecture Specification (block-level implementation)
- **Simplified RV32I: kestrel** - Tutorial-study book this core is documented by
- **RISC-V Falcon Suite README** - Suite overview and rung ladder
- **RISC-V Unprivileged ISA** - ISA authority (cited by chapter)
- **Testplans** - V&V cross-reference (six plans)

Last Updated: 2026-10-07 **Maintained By:** RTL Design Sherpa Project

18 Simplified RV32I: kestrel

Source: The RISC-V Instruction Set Manual, Volume I: Unprivileged Architecture (riscv-spec.pdf, chapter-cited; this book cites chapters and sections, not pages) and the falcon-suite design documentation **Edition:** Simplified for the kestrel-rv32i single-cycle core, rung 1 of the falcon suite. Derived from condensed study notes; emphasis is on what the as-built kestrel core actually does and verifies, with the RISC-V specification cited as the authority. **Version:** 0.2 **Last Updated:** 2026-10-20 **Status:** Draft. Personal study notes.

18.1 Overview

RV32I is the RISC-V base integer instruction set: thirty-seven instructions, six instruction formats, thirty-one general-purpose registers plus the hard-wired zero register, and a program counter. It is small enough to hold in your head and rich enough to run real compiled code. That combination makes it the canonical teaching ISA — and the foundation rung of the falcon suite.

kestrel is the suite's rung-1 core: a single-cycle RV32I implementation in which one instruction retires per clock and the whole machine — fetch, decode, register read, execute, memory access, writeback — completes inside that clock. There is no pipeline, no hazard logic, no trap machinery, and almost no control state. What there is, is a datapath you can trace by hand and a decode truth table you can read top to bottom.

This book condenses RV32I into the material needed to understand kestrel: the instruction set itself (Chapter 2), the datapath (Chapter 3), the control truth table (Chapter 4), the memory contract including the hardware-misaligned policy (Chapter 5), the verification story — the rv32ui battery, spike lockstep, and the riscv-formal proof that caught a bug forty-two directed tests missed (Chapter 6) — and what the single-cycle discipline costs, which is exactly what motivates rung 2, merlin (Chapter 7).

18.2 Document Structure

18.2.1 Chapter 1: Introduction

- 01_introduction.md - What this book is, what kestrel is, how to read the as-built core
- 02_the_falcon_ladder.md - The four-rung suite, why kestrel is rung 1, what each rung teaches
- 03_conventions.md - Notation, register names, halt-versus-trap terminology, citations

18.2.2 Chapter 2: The RV32I ISA Quick Reference

- 01_formats.md - The six instruction formats and how immediates are assembled
- 02_the_instruction_set.md - The thirty-seven base instructions, group by group
- 03_system_layer.md - What kestrel does with FENCE, ECALL/EBREAK, MRET, and the CSR class

18.2.3 Chapter 3: The kestrel Datapath

- 01_overview.md - Block-level tour, the module list, the complete state inventory
- 02_a_cycle_in_detail.md - One clock, end to end: fetch, decode, execute, writeback
- 03_control_state.md - The five state elements and why there is no FSM
- 04_rvfi.md - The RVFI retire interface and how kestrel aggregates it

18.2.4 Chapter 4: The Control Truth Table

- 01_the_control_bundle.md - The thirteen decode outputs and the default bundle
- 02_the_decode_table.md - The full decode case as a table, every row

18.2.5 Chapter 5: The Memory Contract

- 01_the_contract.md - The Harvard interface, word-wide buses, combinational reads
- 02_misaligned_data.md - The hardware-misaligned decision: rotation, the retry cycle, RVFI encoding

- 03_ialign_and_halt.md - IALIGN=32, the instruction-side misaligned halt, the four halt causes

18.2.6 Chapter 6: Verification

- 01_testbench_and_golden.md - The cocotb testbench, sampling contract, golden interpreter lockstep
- 02_rv32ui_battery.md - The 42-test rv32ui-p-* battery, results table, verdict protocol
- 03_spike_lockstep.md - Spike 1.1.0 lockstep, the misaligned-build note, stream-diff details
- 04_riscv_formal.md - The riscv-formal flow: wrapper, checks, depths, 42/42
- 05_the_cex_story.md - The misaligned-jump counterexample: a real bug the battery missed

18.2.7 Chapter 7: What kestrel Costs

- 01_what_kestrel_costs.md - CPI 1 and its price: the whole machine on the critical path
- 02_merlin_teaser.md - The five-stage answer and what carries over unchanged

---

18.2.8 Version History

Version history

Version	Date	Change
0.1	2026-10-06	First draft
0.2	2026-10-20	Section (h2) headings now open a new page, the pipeline default. No technical content changed.

RTL Design Sherpa · Learning Hardware Design Through Practice GitHub · Documentation Index · MIT License

---

19 RISC-V Falcon Suite

Five independent, clean-slate RISC-V cores whose primary product is **education**, in the same spirit as the pumice/scoria/andesite memory-controller line. Each rung is a complete, verified, documented design small enough to hold in your head; the rungs ascend in microarchitectural complexity so the *diff between neighbors is the lesson*. Rungs do not share RTL — each core is the cleanest possible example of its level, not the cheapest to produce. Educational benefit over IP; no rung chases performance or benchmarks.

Design spec (source of truth for scope, ISA, verification, packaging): `docs/superpowers/specs/2026-10-06-riscv-falcon-suite-design.md`.

19.1 The ladder

Each rung carries a raptor-codename, real falcons first (species in strict size order, tracking complexity). The falcon run ends at gyrfalcon — the largest living species — so the top rung steps deliberately to mythology: garuda, the giant divine raptor, king of birds, one past the largest falcon. The codename is the RTL identifier prefix and the module/package prefix; the DIRECTORY is the compound `<codename>-<isa>` form — `kestrel-rv32i`, not `kestrel`. The bare codename is how the core is referred to in prose ("kestrel sees the whole machine in one cycle").

Directory	Codename	ISA	Microarchitecture	Status
`kestrel-rv32i/`	**kestrel**	RV32I	single-cycle	RTL complete; rv32ui battery 42/42 with spike lockstep; riscv-formal 42/42; doc book v0.1 published; board loader sim-verified
`merlin-rv32i/`	**merlin**	RV32I	5-stage in-order pipeline	Planned; structure only
`peregrine-rv32im/`	**peregrine**	RV32IM	advanced in-order: predictor, traps, L1 caches, AXI master	Planned; structure only
`gyrfalcon-rv32ima/`	**gyrfalcon**	RV32IM baseline; gyrfalcon-A flavor RV32IMA	out-of-order capstone: rename, ROB, reservation stations; two flavors — baseline and gyrfalcon-A (`A_EXT=1`:	Planned; structure only

Directory	Codename	ISA	Microarchitecture	Status
			LR/SC + AMO atomics study)	
`garuda-rv32imaf/`	**garuda**	RV32IMAF	gyrfalcon's OoO plus an FPU: FP register file + rename, fcsr precise flags, non-pipelined long-latency units	Planned; structure only (penciled in; beyond the 2026-10-06 design spec, which pins four rungs)

19.1.1 Moved: hive-serv

hive-serv — the SERV-based control/monitoring system (1 VexRiscv control plane + 16 SERV monitor cores) — left this area 2026-10-13 for `compute-eng-ip/hive-serv`: it *uses* RISC-V cores rather than teaching one, and it is the control half of the compute family (its other half is the cell CGRA), not a falcon-ladder rung. This directory is the ladder again, nothing more.

19.1.2 Tetrad engine: gatling-rv32itetrad

gatling-rv32itetrad/ is not a ladder rung either — it is the compute family's tetrad engine (owner PRD 2026-10-17): a barrel RV32I core with the Xcell extension (CFG/POP/PUSH/ECTX, custom-0), one engine per tetrad with four contexts — the four cells — sharing one F/D/X/W datapath. It replaces the cell PRD's ALU + execution-FSM block ("the program is the config") and answers the kestrel-for-the-compute-FSM question in kestrel's own lineage: same RV32I contract and lockstep flow, inverted pipeline lesson — N contexts hide one shared datapath's latency instead of stages hiding latency for one stream. Open decisions and its interface to the bf16 alu-infer block are tracked in vault TASK-001.

19.2 Goals per rung

kestrel — see everything. Single-cycle RV32I: PC, register file, ALU, immediate generator, control as an explicit decode truth table, a plainly documented combinational-read memory contract. The hovering falcon: the whole machine is visible in one cycle — including its cost, since the critical path *is* the machine, which is exactly the motivation for merlin. **Delivers:** the ISA (R/I/S/B/U/J formats, the full base integer set), the datapath, honest control logic.

merlin — flow it. The classic IF/ID/EX/MEM/WB pipeline on the deliberately identical RV32I ISA, so students diff *behavior*, not ISA. Forwarding from EX/MEM and MEM/WB with explicit priority, load-use interlock stall, branches resolved in EX predict-not-taken with flush. **Delivers:** pipeline registers, RAW hazards, forwarding priority, the load-use bubble, control-hazard flushes, why branch resolution stage matters.

peregrine — speed it up. Advanced in-order RV32IM: iterative multicycle multiply/divide (the structural-hazard lesson), BTB + 2-bit bimodal prediction with mispredict recovery, machine-mode CSRs with precise exceptions and CLINT-shaped interrupts, split blocking write-back L1 caches behind an AXI4 master on the repo fabric with MonBus visibility. **Delivers:** speculation and recovery, precise exceptions, the memory hierarchy, bus protocol — and ties the whole repo together (memory controllers, cache IP line, AMBA fabric).

gyrfalcon — hide everything. Out-of-order capstone in two flavors (added 2026-10-11): the baseline — peregrine's RV32IM exactly — and gyrfalcon-A (`A_EXT=1`): LR/SC reservations, store-conditional failure, and AMOs, the atomicity study — so every peregrine battery still carries in both. Dual-issue dispatch, explicit rename map + free list, 32-entry ROB with in-order commit, three reservation stations, wakeup/select over common data buses, speculative dispatch with checkpoint-restore rename rollback. **Delivers:** register renaming and WAR/WAW elimination, the ROB as an undo log, out-of-order completion with in-order retirement — the honest, complete OOO story — and the atomicity study: reservations, SC failure, AMOs, acquire/release as memory-model operations.

garuda — float it. The RV32IMAF delta on gyrfalcon's OoO: a 32-entry FP register file with its own rename, an `fcsr` whose five accrued exception flags (NV/DZ/OF/UF/NX) stay precise-exception-clean through the ROB, and the repo's ieee754 fp32 arithmetic behind the reservation stations — multi-cycle FMUL/FADD and the non-pipelined Goldschmidt FDIV / Newton-rsqrt FSQRT (9–11 cycle class) as the long-latency-unit lesson. Rounding hard-wired RNE; any other requested mode raises NV, keeping the CSR story honest without a dynamic rounding-mode datapath. **Delivers:** long-latency execution scheduling, FP architectural state, and the F-extension ISA delta (F regs, `fcsr`, FMV/FCVT/FSGNJ/FCLASS) — consuming the math library's `math_ieee754_2008_fp32_*` blocks end-to-end.

19.3 Packaging (per rung, the MC-line treatment)

- **Doc book** — *Simplified RV32I: kestrel* and successors, Memory Notes branding, built through `bin/md_to_docx.py` to DOCX/PDF, following the Simplified DFI books' precedent. Each book lives in its rung's `docs/`; the kestrel edition is published at `kestrel-rv32i/docs/simplified_rv32i/`.
- **Formal** — riscv-formal-style ISA compliance where it pays: full on kestrel, retire-interface on merlin, targeted properties (exception precision, recovery, in-order commit, deadlock freedom) on peregrine/gyrfalcon.
- **Golden model** — spike ISS lockstep in the rds-dv cocotb framework; the classic `rv32ui`/`rv32um` riscv-tests batteries as the compliance gate.
- **Drill app** — `bin/apps/core_drills` (ddr_drills architecture): pipeline stage-viewer with forwarding arrows, hazard quiz, branch-predictor drill, and a rename/ROB viewer. App design gets its own doc once merlin's RTL is fixed.

19.4 References and layout

Common primary sources (the RISC-V ISA manuals) live in `references/` and are cited by chapter, not page.

Per-rung skeleton follows the dma-ip/stream component layout convention: `rtl/`, `docs/`, `dv/` (cocotb + lockstep testbenches). Shared suite doctrine lands in `docs/` as it is written. Per-rung `PRD.md`/`CLAUDE.md` arrive with each rung's implementation plan.

20 RISC-V Formal Interface (RVFI)

20.1 RVFI Specification

In the following specification the term XLEN refers to the width of an x register in bits, as described in the RISC-V ISA specification. The term NRET refers to the maximum number of instructions that the core under test can retire in one cycle. If more than one of the retired instruction writes the same register, the channel with the highest index contains the instruction that wins the conflict. The term ILEN refers to the maximum instruction width for the processor under test.

The Interface consists only of output signals. Each signal is a concatenation of NRET values of constant width, effectively creating NRET channels. For simplicity, the following descriptions refer to one such channel. For example, we refer to rvfi_valid as a 1-bit signal, not a NRET-bits signal.

20.1.1 Instruction Metadata

```
output [NRET        - 1 : 0] rvfi_valid
output [NRET *   64 - 1 : 0] rvfi_order
output [NRET * ILEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_insn
output [NRET        - 1 : 0] rvfi_trap
output [NRET        - 1 : 0] rvfi_halt
output [NRET        - 1 : 0] rvfi_intr
output [NRET * 2    - 1 : 0] rvfi_mode
output [NRET * 2    - 1 : 0] rvfi_ixl
```

When the core retires an instruction, it asserts the rvfi_valid signal and uses the signals described below to output the details of the retired instruction. The signals below are only valid during such a cycle and can be driven to arbitrary values in a cycle in which rvfi_valid is not asserted.

The rvfi_order field must be set to the instruction index. No indices must be used twice and there must be no gaps. Instructions may be retired in a reordered fashion, as long as causality is preserved (register and memory write operations must be retired before the read operations that depend on them).

rvfi_insn is the instruction word for the retired instruction. In case of an instruction with fewer than ILEN bits, the upper bits of this output must be all zero. For compressed instructions the compressed instruction word must be output on this port. For fused instructions the complete fused instruction sequence must be output.

rvfi_trap must be set for an instruction that cannot be decoded as a legal instruction, such as 0x00000000.

In addition, rvfi_trap must be set for a misaligned memory read or write in PMAs that don't allow misaligned access, or other memory access violations. rvfi_trap must also be set for a jump instruction that jumps to a misaligned instruction.

The signal `rvfi_halt` must be set when the instruction is the last instruction that the core retires before halting execution. It should not be set for an instruction that triggers a trap condition if the CPU reacts to the trap by executing a trap handler. This signal enables verification of liveness properties.

`rvfi_intr` must be set for the first instruction that is part of a trap handler, i.e. an instruction that has a `rvfi_pc_rdata` that does not match the `rvfi_pc_wdata` of the previous instruction.

`rvfi_mode` must be set to the current privilege level, using the following encoding: 0=U-Mode, 1=S-Mode, 2=Reserved, 3=M-Mode

Finally `rvfi_ixl` must be set to the value of MXL/SXL/UXL in the current privilege level, using the following encoding: 1=32, 2=64

20.1.2 Integer Register Read/Write

```
output [NRET *    5 - 1 : 0] rvfi_rs1_addr
output [NRET *    5 - 1 : 0] rvfi_rs2_addr
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_rs1_rdata
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_rs2_rdata
```

`rvfi_rs1_addr` and `rvfi_rs2_addr` are the decoded `rs1` and `rs1` register addresses for the retired instruction. For an instruction that reads no `rs1`/`rs2` register, this output can have an arbitrary value. However, if this output is nonzero then `rvfi_rs1_rdata` must carry the value stored in that register in the pre-state.

`rvfi_rs1_rdata`/`rvfi_rs2_rdata` is the value of the `x` register addressed by `rs1`/`rs2` before execution of this instruction. This output must be zero when `rs1`/`rs2` is zero.

```
output [NRET *    5 - 1 : 0] rvfi_rd_addr
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_rd_wdata
```

`rvfi_rd_addr` is the decoded `rd` register address for the retired instruction. For an instruction that writes no `rd` register, this output must always be zero.

`rvfi_rd_wdata` is the value of the `x` register addressed by `rd` after execution of this instruction. This output must be zero when `rd` is zero.

20.1.3 Program Counter

```
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_pc_rdata
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_pc_wdata
```

This is the program counter (`pc`) before (`rvfi_pc_rdata`) and after (`rvfi_pc_wdata`) execution of this instruction. I.e. this is the address of the retired instruction and the address of the next instruction.

20.1.4 Memory Access

```
output [NRET * XLEN   - 1 : 0] rvfi_mem_addr
output [NRET * XLEN/8 - 1 : 0] rvfi_mem_rmask
```

```
output [NRET * XLEN/8 - 1 : 0] rvfi_mem_wmask
output [NRET * XLEN   - 1 : 0] rvfi_mem_rdata
output [NRET * XLEN   - 1 : 0] rvfi_mem_wdata
```

For memory operations (`rvfi_mem_rmask` and/or `rvfi_mem_wmask` are non-zero), `rvfi_mem_addr` holds the accessed memory location.

When the define `RISCV_FORMAL_ALIGNED_MEM` is set, the address must have a 4-byte alignment for `XLEN=32` and an 8-byte alignment for `XLEN=64`. When the define is not set, then the address must point directly to the LSB or the word / half word / byte that is accessed.

`rvfi_mem_rmask` is a bitmask that specifies which bytes in `rvfi_mem_rdata` contain valid read data from `rvfi_mem_addr`.

`rvfi_mem_wmask` is a bitmask that specifies which bytes in `rvfi_mem_wdata` contain valid data that is written to `rvfi_mem_addr`.

`rvfi_mem_rdata` is the pre-state data read from `rvfi_mem_addr`. `rvfi_mem_rmask` specifies which bytes are valid.

`rvfi_mem_wdata` is the post-state data written to `rvfi_mem_addr`. `rvfi_mem_wmask` specifies which bytes are valid.

When `RISCV_FORMAL_ALIGNED_MEM` is set then `riscv-formal` assumes that unaligned memory access causes a trap.

20.1.5 Alternative Arithmetic Operations

Some arithmetic operations (such as multiplication and division) are beyond to practical capabilities of even modern hardware model checkers. In order to still be able to verify things like bypassing for the arithmetic units performing those operations we define a set of alternative arithmetic operations. When the define `RISCV_FORMAL_ALTOPS` is set riscv-formal will expect the processor under test to implement those alternative operations instead.

Commutative operations (like multiplication) are replaced with addition followed by applying XOR with a bitmask that indicates the type of the operation. Noncommutative operations (like division) are replaced with subtraction followed by applying XOR with a bitmask that indicates the type of the operation.

The bitmasks are 64 bits wide. RV32 implementations only use the lower 32 bits of the bitmasks. The `*W` instructions in RV64 (suchg as `MULW`) are implemented by adding or subtracting the lower 32 bits of the operands, then XORing with the lower 32 bits of the bitmask, then sign extending the result to 64 bits.

20.1.5.1 Integer Multiply/Divide Instructions

Operation	Add/Sub	Bitmask
MUL	Add	0x2cdf52a55876063e
MULH	Add	0x15d01651f6583fb7

Operation	Add/Sub	Bitmask
MULHSU	Sub	0xea3969edecfbe137
MULHU	Add	0xd13db50d949ce5e8
DIV	Sub	0x29bbf66f7f8529ec
DIVU	Sub	0x8c629acb10e8fd70
REM	Sub	0xf5b7d8538da68fa5
REMU	Sub	0xbc4402413138d0e1

20.1.6 Control and Status Registers (CSRs)

For each supported CSR there are four additional output ports:

```
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_csr_<csrname>_rmask
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_csr_<csrname>_wmask
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_csr_<csrname>_rdata
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_csr_<csrname>_wdata
```

The `rmask` and `wmask` ports specify which bits of `rdata` and `wdata` are valid.

It is always valid for an instruction to activate more `rmask`/`rdata` bits than required by the instruction, as long as the reported bits correctly reflect the machine state.

If reading a CSR has side effects, those side effects are not triggered by raised `rmask` bits but by the type of the instruction.

The Verilog define `RISCV_FORMAL_CSR_<CSRNAME>` must be set for each CSR traced via RVFI by the core under test.

See RISC-V Formal CSR Sematics for the exact semantics of CSR values output via RVFI.

20.1.7 Handling of Speculative Execution

Out-of-order cores that execute speculatively can commit speculative instructions on RVFI.

Rollbacks must be output via the rollback interface, that is enabled when `RISCV_FORMAL_ROLLBACK` is defined:

```
output [ 0 : 0] rvfi_rollback_valid
output [63 : 0] rvfi_rollback_order
```

All RVFI packets output *prior* to the cycle with asserted `rvfi_rollback_valid` with a `rvfi_order` field of *greater or equal* to `rvfi_rollback_order` are invalidated by a rollback event.

RVFI packets output in the same cycle as `rvfi_rollback_valid` are already part of the new instruction stream re-starting at the instruction number indicated in `rvfi_rollback_order`.

20.2 RVFI TODOs and Requests for Comments

The following section contains notes on future extensions to RVFI. They will come part of the spec as soon as there is at least one core that implements the feature, and a matching formal check that utilises the feature. In many cases the additional ports will only be used (and expected from the core) when additional to-be-defined `RISCV_FORMAL_*` Verilog defines are set.

20.2.1 Support for fused instructions

Fused instructions are simply handled as larger instructions in RVFI. Additional `rvfi_rs*` ports (or even `rvfi_rd*` ports) may be added to accommodate the fused instructions.

No instruction models for fused instructions have been created yet.

Alternatively fused instructions may be output as individual instructions in separate RVFI channels.

20.2.2 Modelling of Floating-Point State

The following is the proposed RVFI extension for floating point ISAs:

```
output [NRET *    5 - 1 : 0] rvfi_frs1_addr
output [NRET *    5 - 1 : 0] rvfi_frs2_addr
output [NRET *    5 - 1 : 0] rvfi_frs3_addr
output [NRET *    5 - 1 : 0] rvfi_frd_addr
output [NRET        - 1 : 0] rvfi_frs1_rvalid
output [NRET        - 1 : 0] rvfi_frs2_rvalid
output [NRET        - 1 : 0] rvfi_frs3_rvalid
output [NRET        - 1 : 0] rvfi_frd_wvalid
output [NRET * FLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_frs1_rdata
output [NRET * FLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_frs2_rdata
output [NRET * FLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_frs3_rdata
output [NRET * FLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_frd_wdata
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_csr_fcsr_rmask
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_csr_fcsr_wmask
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_csr_fcsr_rdata
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_csr_fcsr_wdata
```

Since `f0` is not a zero register, additional `*_[rw]valid` signals are required to indicate if `frs1`, `frs2`, `frs3`, and `frd` and their corresponding pre- or post-values are valid.

Alternative arithmetic operations (`RISCV_FORMAL_ALTOPS`) will be defined for all non-trivial floating point operations.

20.2.3 Modelling of Virtual Memory

For processors with support for S-mode and virtual memory we define the following additional RVFI signals for data load/stores:

```
output [NRET *   64 - 1 : 0] rvfi_mem_paddr
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_mem_pte0
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_mem_pte1
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_mem_pte2
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_mem_pte3
```

And the following additional RVFI signals for instruction fetches:

```
output [NRET *   64 - 1 : 0] rvfi_pc_paddr
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_pc_pte0
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_pc_pte1
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_pc_pte2
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_pc_pte3
```

And we require that the `satp` CSR is observable through RVFI:

```
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_csr_satp_rmask
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_csr_satp_wmask
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_csr_satp_rdata
output [NRET * XLEN - 1 : 0] rvfi_csr_satp_wdata
```

The `rvfi_mem_paddr` field carries the physical address of the memory access. The `rvfi_mem_pte[0123]` fields carry the values of the page table entries used to convert `rvfi_mem_addr` to `rvfi_mem_paddr`. Unused `rvfi_mem_pte[0123]` fields must always be set to zero.

For memory accesses in M-mode, or with `satp.MODE=0`, `rvfi_mem_paddr` must have the same value as `rvfi_mem_addr` and all four `rvfi_mem_pte[0123]` fields must be set to zero.

For example in Sv32 mode, modulo missing fences, `rvfi_mem_pte1` must carry the value of the 32-bit word at the following memory location:

```
pt1 = rvfi_csr_satp_rdata & 0x003fffff
vpn1 = (rvfi_mem_addr >> 22) & 0x3ff
pte1_addr = (pt1 << 12) | (vpn1 << 2)
```

And `rvfi_mem_pte0` must carry the value of the 32-bit word at the following memory location (or zero if `pte1.X` or `pte1.R` or `!pte1.V`):

```
pt0 = rvfi_mem_pte1 >> 10
vpn0 = (rvfi_mem_addr >> 12) & 0x3ff
pte0_addr = (pt0 << 12) | (vpn0 << 2)
```

Finally, `rvfi_mem_paddr` must be set to the following address:

```
ppn = rvfi_mem_pte0 >> 10
offset = rvfi_mem_addr & 0xfff
rvfi_mem_paddr = (ppn << 12) | offset
```

20.2.4 Modelling of Atomic Memory Operations

AMO instructions (`AMOSWAP.W`, etc.) can be modelled using the existing `rvfi_mem_*` interface by asserting bits in both `rvfi_mem_rmask` and `rvfi_mem_wmask`.

There is also no extension to the RVFI port necessary to accommodate the `LR`, `SC`, `FENCE` and `FENCE.I` instructions.

Verification of this instructions for a single-core systems can be done using the RVFI port only. A strategy must be defined to verify their correct behavior in multicore systems.

For atomic instructions with `rd = x0` a core might have no way of knowing the old or new value of the memory location. For those situations we add an additional RVFI output port:

```
output [NRET           - 1 : 0] rvfi_mem_extamo
```

When `rvfi_mem_extamo` is set, `rvfi_mem_wdata` carries the `rs2` value used with the atomic instruction instead of the new value in the memory location. `rvfi_mem_rmask` is all-zeros in this case.

20.2.5 Skipping instructions

Consider the following sequence of instructions:

```
    ....
    add t0,t1,t2
    beqz t3,label
    sub t0,t1,t3
label:
    ....
```

When t3 has a non-zero value the processor could decide not to schedule the add instruction because its value is never going to be used. In this case the processor would be unable to produce a valid RVFI trace for the instruction sequence.

An additional signal can be added to RVFI that can be used to mark such instructions:

```
output [NRET         - 1 : 0] rvfi_skip
```

When `rvfi_skip` is high the core may output arbitrary data on the `*_rdata` and `*_wdata` ports (excluding `rvfi_pc_rdata` and `rvfi_pc_wdata`). The register values written by such intrustions may only be observed by other skipped instructions. An additional formal proof must be added to check this property.

Memory operations (`rvfi_mem_rmask` and/or `rvfi_mem_wmask` are non-zero) can not be skipped.

21 kestrel-rv32i Testplans

YAML testplans mapping every kestrel FUB and the core top to the cocotb/pytest tests that exercise them. Format mirrors the pumice/retro_legacy_blocks testplan convention so the same coverage rollup applies (`bin/cov_utils/functional_coverage_tracker.py`).

21.1 Inventory

Testplan	Module	Test file(s)	Scenarios	Verified	Not impl.
`kestrel_regfile_testplan.yaml`	kestrel_regfile.sv	test_kestrel_regfile.py	5	5	0
`kestrel_alu_testplan.yaml`	kestrel_alu.sv	test_kestrel_decode.py	5	5	0
`kestrel_imm_gen_testplan.yaml`	kestrel_imm_gen.sv	test_kestrel_decode.py	6	6	0
`kestrel_decode_testplan.yaml`	kestrel_decode.sv	test_kestrel_decode.py	12	12	0
`kestrel_mem_loader_testplan.yaml`	kestrel_mem_loader.sv	test_kestrel_mem_loader.py	9	9	0
`kestrel_core_testplan.yaml`	kestrel_core.sv	test_kestrel_{core,branch,ls,rv32ui,mem_loader,fuzz}.py	18	17	1
Total			**55**	**54**	**1**

Not-implemented scenarios and why:

- **CORE-18** — functional coverage closure / cover model (**Phase C**).

21.2 What each plan covers

- **RF (kestrel_regfile)**: reset-to-zero, write/readback on both ports, read-during-write old-value, x0 discard, independent port addressing (attributed to the core-level golden trace, RF-05).
- **ALU (kestrel_alu)**: exhaustive 10-op x 16-value x 16-value golden-model sweep including shamt=`b[4:0]`, signed/unsigned compare flags. The flags are unconnected inside kestrel_core by design (branch comparator is separate) — verified at unit level only.
- **IG (kestrel_imm_gen)**: I/S/B/U/J immediate assembly and sign extension with directed ±vectors; B/J LSB-zero rule; plus a SEED-driven randomized sweep (625 vectors, opcode+funct3 anchored per format class) against the Python `imm_golden`.
- **DEC (kestrel_decode)**: the 48-encoding golden truth table (37 canonical RV32I + mret + fence/fence.i + ecall/ebreak + all 6 CSR-stub forms), illegal / reserved encodings landing on halt cause 0xF, ecall/ebreak causes 1/2. Halt cause 3 (IALIGN) is decode-invisible by design and lives in the CORE plan (CORE-13).
- **ML (kestrel_mem_loader)**: AXIL window over both 64 KB regions, per-byte wstrb merge, CTRL.run readback/release sequencing, load-mode isolation (core_rst_n hold, parked PC, no retirement), core↔dmem cross-mux both directions, run-mode observability through the AXIL port, AXIL backpressure (bready/rready held low — bvalid/rvalid hold, busy taps, no lost beat), run-mode loader-write rejection (post-CTRL.run poison write leaves the arrays untouched, B still OKAY), and the golden-trace board path (battery images streamed over AXIL with spike lockstep).
- **CORE (kestrel_core)**: ISA classes via golden trace, branches/jumps (incl. IALIGN halt cause 3), loads/stores incl. the cross-word 2-cycle retry, the system layer (FENCE NOPs, ECALL/EBREAK halt+hold, illegal halt, trap-beat shape), RVFI invariants, the 42-image rv32ui battery, spike lockstep, and the CORE-17 constrained-random fuzz (seeded streams vs the interpreter full-field diff plus spike lockstep at every level). Phase C gap (coverage closure) is tracked as not_implemented.

21.3 JUnit naming convention (observed)

Kestrel's pytest wrappers launch one Verilator build per (cocotb testcase, test level) cell; each cell writes a cocotb JUnit XML whose testcase `name` is the **cocotb test function name**, with the pytest module as `classname`:

```
<testcase name="cocotb_test_kestrel_core_focus"
classname="test_kestrel_core" .../>
```

So `test_function` strings in these plans quote the `cocotb_test_*` node names exactly (e.g. `cocotb_test_kestrel_branch_all`, `cocotb_test_kestrel_rv32ui_battery`). They match the tracker by exact name — there are no pytest-parametrized `[case-level]` node names in the cocotb XML.

Results XML layout: the wrappers set `COCOTB_RESULTS_FILE` to `dv/tests/logs/results_<testcase>_<level>.xml`. Both `dv/tests/logs/` and `dv/tests/local_sim_build/` are gitignored — nothing is checked in; every run regenerates them. The per-cell cocotb XMLs also land one level down at `dv/tests/local_sim_build/<testcase>_<level>/<rand>_results.xml` with identical testcase names, so to feed the tracker from a previous local run, flatten its XMLs first:

```
cd projects/components/riscv-ip/kestrel-rv32i/dv/tests
find local_sim_build -name '*_results.xml' -exec cp {} logs/ \;
```

21.4 Rollup

```
# From the repo root, after a regression (or after flattening a
previous
# local run's XMLs into dv/tests/logs/ as above):
python3 bin/cov_utils/functional_coverage_tracker.py \
    --testplans-dir
projects/components/riscv-ip/kestrel-rv32i/dv/testplans \
    --report \
    --results-dir
projects/components/riscv-ip/kestrel-rv32i/dv/tests/logs
```

The tracker exists for per-scenario status verification: it matches each YAML's `test_function` strings against the JUnit XML testcase names and reports whether the referenced cocotb tests actually ran and passed. Its functional-coverage percentage shows 0% for these plans — by design, as in the pumice house: these YAMLs carry no `coverage_points` blocks, so the tool has no cover data to score. The scenario-level rollup for kestrel is each YAML's `implied_coverage` block: `scenario_tracked` counts `status: verified` scenarios and `implied_percentage = tracked / total_scenarios`. Per-scenario `covers_lines` attribution from Verilator `.dat` files is the pumice `update_testplan_coverage.py` workflow and is deliberately not wired in kestrel yet (CORE-18 owns the cover model).

21.5 Running the tests

```
cd projects/components/riscv-ip/kestrel-rv32i/dv/tests
make list                       # discovered test roots
make run-all-func-parallel      # FUNC regression (gate+func cells)
make run-all-full-parallel      # FULL regression (gate+func+full cells)
```

REG_LEVEL semantics: GATE runs gate cells only, FUNC adds func, FULL adds full. The rv32ui battery reads TEST_LEVEL inside the sim (gate = 3-image smoke, func = 42 images + spike lockstep, full = 42 images without lockstep).

21.6 Functional coverage (CORE-18)

Collection is wired through the central `cov_utils` conftest hook (`dv/tests/conftest.py`) — the same pattern every other component uses. To regenerate:

```
make clean-all
COVERAGE=1 make run-all-full
make coverage-report
```

Measured 2026-10-07 across all 60 cells (including the CORE-17 fuzz at full level, 200 streams):

Metric	Result	House target	Status
Line (Verilator)	94.9%	80%	PASS
Line — kestrel_core	100.0%	—	—
Line — kestrel_decode	95.0%	—	—
Line — kestrel_mem_loader	90.1%	—	—

Toggle collection is enabled (`--coverage-toggle`); the house `merge_testlevel_coverage.py` report tracks line only — toggle numbers are ad-hoc from `coverage_data/merged/latest_merged_coverage.dat` via `verilator_coverage`. Known toggle laggards are data-path width toggles exercised thinly by directed tests; the fuzz's random patterns are the planned ratchet. Coverage artifacts (`coverage_data/`, `coverage_reports/`, `local_sim_build/`, `logs/`) are gitignored by design; the numbers above are the committed record, regenerable with the commands in this section.